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Virginia Board of Education, Business Meeting, Thursday, November 19, 2020

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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8fYGbaXRHTY
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-24. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:00:00] way so we should be live here and well we i think we're now live streaming and we're just connecting it to um the board's web page good morning all good morning morning i've not yet seen dr duran just davis vaughn is that right that is correct good morning everyone susan williams here hope everyone's doing well yeah good morning esteemed council we're doing great thank you thanks for

[00:00:38] being with us glad to hear glad to be here good morning everyone and tamala richardson from the

[00:00:46] office of early childhood good morning good morning thanks kevin uh good morning everybody

[00:01:44] just to let you all know we are live streaming on youtube we're waiting on just the last couple of our board members and staff to join us and then we will get started here in just a couple of minutes

[00:02:43] miss davis vaught has joined morning everyone good morning pam how are you very well on this beautiful day. How are you, sir? Doing great, thanks. There's Dr. Duran. Good morning. Oh, there he is. Okay. Now the way the screen gets arranged, sometimes I'm missing.

[00:03:08] Morning, President Gecker. Good morning, Superintendent Duran. All right, Emily, I think we're all here. I saw Dr. Lane too, so are we ready? We are ready. All right. Well, good morning to everybody. Thank you for being with us. Welcome to another meeting of the hardest working board in the commonwealth we are delighted to be here we are still hopeful that one day we can do this again in person you know hopefully while i'm still uh president of the board which

[00:03:45] means sometime before next june so uh you know we still long for the days when we can all get together again but um first thing we will do as we convene the meeting is the roll call of the members. Dr. Mann? Present. Ms. Holton? Present. Dr. Wilson? Present. Ms. Davis-Vaught? Present.

[00:04:10] Dr. Duran? Present. And Dr. Pexton? Present. And I'm pretty sure, although he's not on the screen now for me, I saw that Dr. Lane, secretary of the board, is on the call too. Is that right? Oh, there he is. Okay. Perfect. All right. First thing then is approval of minutes from our October 14 and 15 meetings has everybody had a chance to review the minutes and if so is there either a motion to adopt them as drafted or to amend them president gecker i just have one subtle amendment

[00:04:49] on page 108 um reference to my comment on teaching teaching the course i really was referring to just teaching the content in general since the content um we're talking about content related to the history standard so subtle but didn't want to make note of that okay would you like to propose a change then let me try to pull it up oh yes just teaching content instead of a course okay uh change yeah is that a motion then to adopt the minutes uh with that one change yes sir thank you

[00:05:26] very much is there a second okay thank you dr duran again uh all votes on this by roll call dr mann Aye. Ms. Holton? Aye. Dr. Wilson? Aye. Ms. Davis-Vaught? Aye. Dr. Duran? Aye. Dr. Pexton? Aye. And I vote aye. Okay. Perfect. The usual opening comments. Good morning. Welcome to the Board of Education's virtual meeting. Our meeting today is being streamed live on the VDOE YouTube channel and on the Board's public meeting webpage. We'd like to welcome those joining us on the live stream from across the Commonwealth.

[00:06:06] A couple of things to note about our virtual meeting. One, the board has accepted a written public comment for this meeting. All comments that were received by 5 p.m. on Tuesday have been uploaded to our meeting webpage and shared with board members in time for them to review in advance of today's meeting.

[00:06:23] Comments received after 5 p.m. on Tuesday will be provided to the board in a timely manner. Two, for our YouTube watchers, the chat feature is disabled as it is not monitored by staff. The best way to contact the board is by email at B, as in board, OE, at D, as in department of, excuse me, DOE.virginia.gov.

[00:06:46] Since we are meeting virtually, as just noted, there's a need for roll call vote for each item. Please be sure to speak clearly so staff can accurately capture your vote for the meeting minutes. Okay, first item then is the consent agenda, items A through D.

[00:07:05] Is there a motion either to adopt the consent items or to pull one or more of those items? President Gecker, I move to adopt the consent agenda as provided. Thank you, Dr. Wilson.

[00:07:22] Is there a second to that motion? I second. Thank you, Dr. Pexton. Any discussion on it? Seeing none again by roll call. Dr. Mann. Aye. Ms. Holton. Aye. Thank you. Dr. Wilson. Aye. Ms. Davis-Vaught. Aye. Dr. Duran. Aye. And Dr. Pexton. Aye. And I vote aye. Okay. That brings us to item E, final review of a

process to certify a list of qualified persons for the Office of Division Superintendents of Schools. Ms. Pitts, I believe this is you.

[00:08:01] yes it is thank you good morning president gecker members of the board and dr lane this item is the final review of a process to certify a list of qualified persons for the office of division superintendent of schools i previously presented the details of this item therefore i will provide only a quick recap the constitution of virginia requires the board of education to certify two school boards, a list of qualified persons for the office of division superintendent.

[00:08:35] Since 1993, Virginia has issued a division superintendent license, and those individuals' names have been placed on the eligible list of division superintendents. A process for the board to certify the eligible list is on page J of this item.

[00:08:55] I shared with the board the concerns from the Virginia School Boards Association regarding timelines and confidentiality issues and during your october meeting you requested that susan williams and i reach out to the sba again to seek any additional recommendations on how to address this matter and the sba recommended the following board of education members who are employed by local school boards should not be given information about applicants from their own school divisions

[00:09:32] names of applicants should be kept confidential until approved by the board of education the board of education should commit to an expedited process to approve applications within seven days when necessary for the school board to appoint its preferred candidate a change in the constitution that removes the process of requiring the board of education to certify the list of qualified individuals. The Superintendent of Public Instruction recommends that the Board of

[00:10:06] Education approve the process to certify a list of qualified persons for the Office of Division Superintendent of Schools. And I'm happy to address any questions that you may have. Thank you, Ms. Pitts. Are there any questions or comments? I have a couple of questions for Ms. Pitts.

[00:10:27] so miss pitts thanks so much for uh to you and ms williams for going back to vsba and and asking for input and the four recommendations or suggestions that they made what i haven't heard would be helpful um what how might the department respond to the concerns or the suggestions that vsba has raised i imagine that for a number of them there's already a i'm sorry yeah i just clicked myself out sorry there's already a process in place that would address some of the concerns or a number of

[00:11:05] the concerns that they've raised so if you could vocalize what that process looks like to address those issues that they've raised thank you sure the first issue or the first suggestion that they made was to not provide board members who are employed by local school boards the information about the applicants ahead of time certainly when someone applies for a license of any nature

[00:11:37] it's not public information until the license is actually issued so we would have to determine whether we would would withhold those names and present them um you know not post them a week before i think that's where their concern is that if we post names ahead of time of individuals that the board will review on a particular date could be problematic for individuals um certainly the

[00:12:08] until the board of education makes the sort of certifies the list we would then issue the license and then it would be on the public query i think the concern is the advanced notice by the sva to the public that these individuals are applying for a license so we would need to narrow that time period when they are out in the public. The expedited process would be up to the board

[00:12:39] to let us know if you are amenable to additional meetings when those types of cases arise and the last certainly would be up to, you know, there would have to be a bill with the General Assembly to change the constitution and that would be a long process to make that revision and certainly they understand that. Thank you. You're welcome.

[00:13:14] Thank you. Thank you, Ms. Pitts, for conferring with them. The change to the Constitution, I think we put in a different category. I personally don't have any interest in pursuing that, and we can't do it anyway. It's not within our authority to accomplish it, but the other three, I would be eager to do everything we can on. My question to you is, particularly the expedited process not not every superintendent hiring is going to require an expedited process presumably i mean many of them will already be on the list many of them they may be making a

[00:13:51] decision but the you know there may be sufficient time to do it under a more normal circum a more normal process but if we do need to do an ex data if the board is willing to do an expedited process on the occasions when needed are the mechanics of that and maybe this question is to Ms. Webb or Dr. Lane as well as to you but what are the mechanics of getting that done can we make that happen to do it expedited either within seven days or with in some short time window if we

[00:14:27] if the board is willing can we make the mechanics of that work? Emily do you want to respond to that because certainly the board meetings have to be noticed yeah we so we do have to publicly notice all board meetings uh within three business days um and obviously we typically notice board meetings at least a week in advance with all of the materials um and we post your public schedule you know what for the next year well in advance um there has been an instance um not this past

[00:15:04] April but the April before when the board met with Governor Northam and we did publicly notice that meeting you know just a couple days in advance because it was a called meeting that was separate from your traditional board meeting so it's not unheard of you know the mechanics of it we could certainly work out if if that instance arose I think right now and while we have the capabilities to meet virtually it would be relatively easy to do um once we move back into an in-person setting

[00:15:40] having folks come to richmond um you know may be more challenging certainly we can have some people outside of richmond as long as we have that quorum in richmond meeting um so there are some logistics that we would have to work out but i don't think it's completely unreasonable to do on on a shorter notice than what we we would typically you know notice meetings and have our agenda items ready so for what it's worth maybe this is moving into discussion rather than question but i i'm comfortable at this point going forward with the the proposed item as written

[00:16:20] but with the commitment that we will do our best to expedite on cases where it is truly necessary and recognizing there may be some gray area there but you know if somebody's announcing a superintendent that's not going to start work for six months you know they can announce the superintendent subject to approval uh through the board of ed and then it may not require an expedited meeting but where there are cases where the hiring decision may actually hinge and the closing the deal may actually hinge on on our meeting then i propose that we do make an

[00:16:56] effort and let's experiment with it for a year or so and you know if we're having to have emergency meetings all the time and if it's extremely uh cumbersome to get that done then you know we'll we'll change it but my guess is that if we do it only when truly necessary and and there may even be some negotiations between um um emily and the divisions over what they and and patty over what exactly that

means but so I don't I don't propose that we need to put that into the the rule language but that we here make the commitment to expedite

[00:17:32] when truly necessary and then we'll see how it goes for a year or so that's just my I am concerned I don't want us to I don't I do think we have a role in approving superintendents I think that's a good role for us to have and I think should exercise our authority but so i'm glad we're moving forward on the item but but i don't want us recognizing how complicated negotiations can be contractual obligations etc i don't want us to do anything to screw up the very very difficult task that board school boards have in

[00:18:08] in hiring their leadership so and miss holton i'll note you know typically speaking the board needs every four weeks with those um handful of months where the board doesn't meet you know so i think think the instances um you know of a true emergency meeting would be more realistic in you know february may august and december when the board doesn't meet um or doesn't have a previously scheduled meeting president dr duran i want to reiterate um miss holton's comments and and thank you for that, Anne.

[00:18:47] With reservation, I will support this. I do have reservations, but I do understand it's our constitutional authority as a board. But if we are committing to try and do what we just said, what Anne just articulated well about making sure that we have the flexibility as much as possible, I don't think any of us want to limit a local school division's authority to choose the superintendent that they believe best meets the needs of their community.

[00:19:12] And I don't think this would do that, But I do think it could cause a potential barrier in timing and in being able to get the folks that are needed. And being a superintendent, having gone through search firm processes, I know that, yes, some of them do take a long time and it shouldn't be a problem.

[00:19:29] But I've also known and experienced and seen where it's a tighter crunch. And so I just want to make sure that we are not limiting a good quality candidate that a school division believes would be the best fit for their community. And I just don't wanna be that barrier is all I'm saying.

[00:19:46] And so whatever we can do to be more flexible, I will support this with that reservation. But I wanna thank Ms. Pitts though, for really reaching out and talking to the various stakeholders and getting that information. And what I know of Ms. Pitts of my time working with her, she too wants to help support districts.

[00:20:05] And she has been doing that. My understanding and you shared with us Ms. Pitts, how you respond very quickly to school boards when they are reaching out for a candidate. So I know that you too want to continue that support and I thank you for what you've done thus far. So I don't want to limit you either in our ability to do that, but we need to just state clarity that we need to do all we can to be flexible when it is an extreme case.

[00:20:27] And to Emily's point, we do meet every four weeks. So school boards should know that schedule. And I would hope that search firms, Ms. Pitts, you can let them know there's nuance here in our Commonwealth, 'cause that's not true necessarily in every other state. And most of these are national firms work there are some we have some local ones and they'll know it well but just making sure everyone knows um i think will be important so but thank you ms pitts because we did ask to pause on this and i could see you did some better thinking and some discussions and so i appreciate you may i may i i'm sorry may i ask one more thing on the item number two the keeping the uh i'm sorry

[00:21:07] item number one from the um the sba that board of ed members who are employed by local school boards should not be given information about applicants from their own school divisions. Do we need to do anything in the proposed rule to address that or can we accommodate that in some other way? Because I do think that's a fair request.

[00:21:31] And we'll say I'm not convinced that as I read this board of ed members, I don't think I would support a situation where some members know more than other members of our board, honestly.

[00:21:46] i think that's a difficult thing and uh we all have been in positions of trust and confidence and i have trust and confidence in the members of the board um you know the fact that people raise concerns which you know we appreciate the input does not mean that each of the concerns need to be addressed i mean some you know people resist change always and uh it's not clear to me frankly that following the constitutional process will in fact uh harm or hinder any division at any

[00:22:22] time and in those cases where it does just to be clear under our bylaws we can call a special meeting you know really at any time i mean that is that's the process assuming we can't do it at a regular meeting but ann i i don't think that i'm in favor of adding anything that would uh put limits on what some of our members know as compared to other members.

[00:22:46] Well, I'm just, I haven't actually thought them through, but I'm just sort of thinking through, say that Dr. Duran, say that one of his top leadership team members is a candidate for the superintendent of, you know, Franklin County. Is there a way that Patty could notify Dr. Duran that there is a matter coming up without telling him whom that he may want to recuse himself as to?

[00:23:15] Or the flip side is somebody, you know, Dr. Duran is applying, God forbid, as a brand new superintendent, I can use you, Francisco, because nobody thinks you're moving anywhere. But as a brand new superintendent in Arlington, if he's interviewing for the job in, you know, Kalamazoo, Virginia, then somebody on our board has got a connection to Kalamazoo.

[00:23:41] it's a recusal situation, but how do you, so how do you get to the point where somebody can recuse themselves without knowing something that it's not helpful to the candidates for them to know? And I don't know, maybe the need for confidentiality is outweighed as Dan suggests by the need for everybody on the board to be included in the discussion, but I at least wanna think it through.

[00:24:07] - For clarification, the process that we're talking about certifying those individuals eligible to receive the division superintendent's license is broad. It's not only for those who come for this job.

[00:24:25] So a superintendent may have a number of individuals who have taken the step to be eligible. That doesn't signal that they are actually in a search at the moment, but they are certified to have.

[00:24:40] So I would be concerned about limiting, to Dan's point, limiting what we all know to try to solve for the concern, perhaps, that VSBA has, which is a smaller subset of applicants for the license.

[00:24:59] So I don't know how we reconcile that. From my perspective, all we are doing today is bringing ourselves in line with a constitutionally mandated process that frankly we haven't done in you know the last 20 years or so uh and you know if this actually becomes an issue as opposed to a theoretical issue i guess we can address changes in process at that point uh although i cannot imagine that i will ever support having some

[00:25:35] members know more than others i just think that's i don't know who makes that decision yeah who gets to know what and uh i think it is not healthy for the long term of any public body to have sort of two classes of members if you will those in the know and those not in the know and but that having been said uh today's action i think is fairly straightforward which is we are mandated to do something we're not currently doing and therefore we're putting in place that process

[00:26:07] to actually do what we're mandated to do. So I'll just chime back in with maybe the right way to think of this is maybe our standard recusal process and the staff as they already do help flagging to us potential issues that we may want to consider recusing ourselves on. Maybe that will be sufficient for the um narrow range of circumstances that that that the vsba is worried about here and uh with that maybe maybe maybe the right thing to do is to go forward with the general

[00:26:46] rule and again watch it for a year or so and if circumstances come up that present a need that can't be addressed by the standard recusal process we deal with it later all right and honestly i I cannot imagine somebody going through a search process who does not meet the base level qualifications to be a division superintendent.

[00:27:06] I don't view this as becoming a process where people get eliminated as they're going coming through. I mean, I don't see how that would happen, honestly. I can only think of one case in the last couple of years where we were approached by a division who wants to appoint somebody who didn't have the base level qualifications.

[00:27:28] And that didn't go far. didn't get to the point of hiring so i would think the process itself would take care of most of these issues okay i'm comfortable i i i defer to your wisdom oh that's a business that's a mistake first mistake of your day hopefully the last not at all okay i don't remember honestly if we had a motion in a second on this or not uh emma i don't believe there was a motion or okay no i get confused uh

[00:28:02] all right then on item one the superintendent has recommended we adopt this and uh dr man was that a motion yes thank you and is there a second second thank you dr wilson uh again by roll call dr man i i'm on mute thank you miss holton aye dr wilson hi miss davis vaught hi dr duran hi

[00:28:37] dr pexton hi perfect all right you know it's always those items that you think will take no time that take a lot of time isn't it just that seems to be there's got to be a corollary to murphy's law somewhere in there uh item f final review of our annual report on the condition and needs of public schools miss webb good morning president gecker vice president wilson members of the board and dr lane i'm pleased to present for final review the board's 2020 annual report on the condition and needs of public schools in Virginia. As you will note in your boilerplate,

[00:29:15] this report is required by section 22.1-18 of the Code of Virginia. This section outlines the requirements of the report, including the current standards of quality, information on student and parent choice, including charter school and virtual school options, as well as a report on the requirements that local school divisions are required to submit to the state and federal government the annual report presents the conditions and needs of public schools an update on the board's work over the past year and a summary of progress and achievement of students and schools as i noted in first review much of this report focuses on relevant research

[00:29:54] to the priorities outlined in your comprehensive plan and your re-prescribed standards of quality since first review there have been several updates to the report on pages four and five an executive

summary has been added on pages six and seven a new introduction has been drafted starting on page seven a lot of new information has been added related to the coven 19 pandemic this includes information on resources made available the operational status of schools the incredible efforts of teachers local school divisions in the department to support students as well as

[00:30:31] information on the digital divide virtual learning challenges and enrollment loss and impacts on average daily membership starting on page 17 a section has been added on early childhood education and on page 26 more information has been added to the board's noteworthy action section throughout the document several technical and editorial updates have been made from board member edits and all of the required reports and the appendices have been added and finalized following board approval and any technical and editorial edits by staff based on board feedback the report will be

[00:31:11] submitted to the governor and general assembly on december 1st the superintendent of public instruction recommends that the board approve the 2020 annual report on the conditions and needs of public schools in Virginia all right any discussion on this just to commend Ms. Webb if I may on the hard work on the first draft and on incorporating feedback on this it's a strong strong document thanks to your hard work and I'm sure that of many others

[00:31:47] yes I really appreciate everybody's feedback I think sometimes there were some conflicting edits which we've tried to to reconcile but i think we have incorporated the bulk of of every board member's edits that um got sent in all right i don't see anybody else but i'd also like to make a comment on this um first of course uh to thank miss webb for the work on this we uh you know there was a time when this was just a very sort of routine document also right the template

[00:32:25] from the year before became the report of the next year a couple years ago we started looking at the report you know with a little bit different eye that is because there are not that many things we put out as a board or approve as a board that actually state our positions and thoughts on specific items the content of the report was deemed you know by our board I think correctly to have a little bit more importance.

[00:32:54] And I will say through that process, Ms. Webb has not only kept up, but really led the board in terms of what ought to be in it. At the same time, last month, I asked board members to weigh in. It's a decent sized document with a lot of detail.

[00:33:13] And I'm very pleased at how many took the time to make meaningful comments and bring up issues that, you know, frankly, are either new or we needed to think about a little bit more. You know, COVID-19 has put us in a position where this report is somewhat difficult to assess our needs at a time when we are not doing many assessments is difficult. We don't have good data yet on the impact of being out of school, of virtual learning, of, you know, not having the

[00:33:50] social contact. We don't know where we are yet and therefore it's difficult to project entirely what we need. But there's a couple things I think the board says, you know, clearly here. The first of which is that the, you know, prescribed standards of quality are important in our view for where we're headed as the commonwealth, as a commonwealth in terms of K-12 education. That the change in direction that they suggest in terms of how we deal with hiring teachers and class size in poor

[00:34:25] areas, the amount of support we need to give our teachers, all that is important. And there is no other document that we put out that states quite as clearly as the annual report. Second, and since the

assembly is not back in session yet, and this is not entirely in our purview, but I think it's important that we note, you know, with enrollment down in so many jurisdictions, uh, under the current funding formulas, there would be, I think the number is 150 million, but there'd be a significant reduction in state funding to, uh, local divisions if the current formulas are used

[00:35:01] as they are written. And, you know, we are, we hope in a period of time that is both unique and brief, but it is clear, I think, to the board and stated clearly in the report that the local divisions cannot do what the local divisions need to do without the funding that they expected based upon prior enrollment. And I hope that message is received well and loudly and clearly by the General Assembly. You know, it's referred to often as the hold harmless, you know, I sort of view it as we're going to give you what we said we would give you and what you expected

[00:35:40] because this situation is completely unexpected, because we understand that you cannot function fully without those funds. And so, you know, we did a legislative briefing the other day, and, you know, I was very pleased with our ability to talk directly to legislators about these issues, and even more pleased that everything that came up is actually discussed in our annual report, and so we had a base reference document to tell people, you know,

[00:36:17] here's what we think, and here's the data to support what we think. So anyway, I know that's sort of the long-winded comment about this, but I am particularly pleased with the work that has been done here. Again, thanks to Emily and all of you and the staff. So with that, is there a motion to approve the final you know the annual report as presented here with the one caveat that if we find any uh you know technical edits you know we get to make them before we finally publish you know in one last read through the document is there a motion to that effect so move president

[00:36:54] director thank you dr wilson second dr duran uh again by roll call dr mann hi miss holton Aye. Dr. Wilson. Aye. Ms. Davis-Vaugh. Aye. Dr. Duran. Aye. Dr. Pexton. Aye. And I, of course, vote aye. So thank you all very much. Okay, item G, final review of revisions to the emergency guidelines for locally awarded verified credits due to COVID-19. Dr. Sale. And Mr. Gecko, I think

[00:37:28] I am going to do a little preamble here before Dr. Sale jumps in. Sorry, Dr. Blaine, if you're not on the agenda you don't get to jump in well go ahead i think it'll be necessary first first let me say thank you for your excellent report on the conditions and needs of public schools and some of what's in your report is why we're coming to you today uh with item g and uh i'm going to take a moment uh to uh talk a little bit about this item and actually my comments will also apply to items

[00:38:03] j and k and so g j and k really do go uh hand in hand and then the other thing that i will say is that uh in order to enact uh the intent of items g j and k uh immediately following the board meeting today there will be uh waivers issued from the superintendent's office and signed by the the secretary uh that that will complement this and i'll try to walk through all of that as we describe it. But I'm sure all the board members are aware of the difficulty all of our school

[00:38:41] divisions are facing in navigating the pandemic. We've provided extensive guidance, metrics to guide their thinking. And if you're not aware, the case numbers throughout the Commonwealth are increasing in many, many localities, especially in our largest localities. And in some of our localities, where there are multiple metrics we look at, but I'll just highlight one. Case incidents per 100,000 people over the last 14 days is one of the core indicators, one of the two core indicators. And some of our largest districts have jumped over 200 cases

[00:39:21] per 100,000 people over the last 14 days. That is the point at which we identify a school division at being high risk or a community transmission rate being at high risk. And where we tend to recommend a larger focus on virtual learning, except for some vulnerable populations.

[00:39:41] Some of our communities, for instance, in Southwest Virginia, are over 700 or 800 cases per 100,000 people. And so what we're starting to see as a trend is that many school divisions that were much more aggressive on in-person opening at the onset are starting to slow their processes.

[00:40:01] In addition to that, even some of those school divisions that are more aggressive have as high as 40% of their students choosing virtual learning. And even though we've all seen some positive news about potential vaccines, we do believe our school divisions will be navigating the pandemic through the remainder of this school year and potentially beyond.

[00:40:23] And for that reason, we have been thinking about not only the students' academic health, their physical and social-emotional health, and have some concerns about students' willingness or even ability to be able to do all assessments in person from the SOL standpoint.

[00:40:47] Now you must keep in mind that the reading, math, and science SOLs that we deliver in Virginia are mandated by the federal government, but we do have flexibility under our waiver and regulatory emergency guideline authority to do some flexibility, especially in the history, social science, and writing areas.

[00:41:09] And so through a combination of your approvals in G, J, and K, and through the waiver authority given to the superintendent's office, we're recommending several things, and Ms. Sale will go into a lot more detail.

[00:41:26] But one of those is that we use this opportunity to leverage a stronger movement towards authentic assessment with assessment being a part of learning. When the board adopted in 2017 your new standards of accreditation, which you're reviewing in your Wednesday meeting, you removed the history and social science assessments from the accreditation process.

[00:41:54] And at that time, the board intended to move towards more authentic assessments. uh there was budget language that uh that that slowed that movement and since that time budget language has been revised uh to allow us a pathway to move towards more of those authentic assessments and so what what we're hoping uh today with this first item that the board will take on is that you will issue flexibility to allow school divisions to do performance assessments and other uh local assessments as a compendium of evidence as part of the locally awarded verified

[00:42:30] credit process without mandating first that students take the sol in person the other thing that this first item does is it expands the range that a student can earn a locally verified awarded verified credit uh outside of history you can still use the locally awarded verified credit process that's traditional but in reading math and science the the major impact will be that by expanding uh the range where students can earn a locally awarded verified credit from 375 to 350 you'll allow students to enter the locally awarded verified credit process earlier after

[00:43:07] first attempting the SOLs in those federally mandated areas. But what that does prevent is students having to come back in person over and over again to retake the SOL to get to the point of 375. We have enough concerns about whether our virtual students will willingly attempt the SOL the first time and

so obviously this is related to verified credits primarily this is uh extremely impactful for our high school students being able to graduate uh and uh based on courses that they

[00:43:42] otherwise would have been successful in um when i come back to talk about writing in the middle school and elementary school assessments i'll go into more detail but this first action item focuses on verified credits expanding the score range which will primarily impact reading math and science and opening up a door for students in the non-federally mandated assessments to enter directly into the verified credit process without having first attempted the SOL. I'll now turn it to Ms. Sale to go into more depth about what is actually in the recommendation and happy to answer

[00:44:17] questions when we when we conclude. Dr. Sale, I'm not sure he actually left you anything to say, but let's uh happy to hear from you. Thank you Dr. Lane for the the introduction and for the preface of this item so item g that's in front of you but first i would like to say good morning to everyone president gecker vice president wilson dr lane and members of the board i really appreciate you all giving me a few minutes of your time this morning to present to you an update of our emergency guidelines for locally awarded verified credits so you all may well remember having

[00:44:53] already reviewed this document or earlier iterations of this document back in the spring when we were really focused on providing our high school students who were unable to earn a verified credit through existing pathways, primarily those SOL end of course assessments, because of the extended school closures in the spring and summer of 2020. So now obviously we have a little bit more perspective of what the shape of instruction and student life looks like in fall 2020 and really kind of speculatively throughout the year. And we recognize the need to provide some similar flexibility to those students that continue to be affected by ongoing

[00:45:31] pandemic conditions so before jumping into some of the details of the document and the revisions that are in the emergency guidelines i just want to quickly note for you all that the proposed revisions were very very intentional that we ensured alignment with what the board and department had set out for local school divisions as expectations for the 2020 and 2021 school year this of course included the new mandate or the mandate on new instruction rather as well as the decision to maintain many of our statutory and regulatory requirements that we consider to be

[00:46:05] the pillars of our high quality educational system so this in part of course includes our assessment program that incorporates sol and of course assessments but also a number of different opportunities that students may have to demonstrate comprehension and mastery of content But as Dr. Lane mentioned, the proposed guidelines here in front of you today also recognize that adapting to new and evolving instructional modalities has been a challenge for some of our learners in Virginia. And this is of course compounding stressors and anxieties that are unprecedented and already based on pandemic conditions. So keeping those things in mind,

[00:46:44] we recognize that all of these things combined might affect a student's ability to perform as successfully on SOL and of course assessments as they might have normally and then for our high school students that of course can translate to a barrier to graduation if they're unable to earn a verified credit that way so in front of you there are two versions of the proposed guidelines you'll notice a red line document that includes strikethroughs and highlights as well as a complete cleaned up document if it's easier to read the the pending

[00:47:18] final item and i will note that the red light red line document probably looks a bit intimidating in terms of the substance of changes but really what that is is that we spent some time reorganizing the document to make it very clear what students are eligible for what locally awarded verified credit processes and then of course making sure that important information is duplicated across the the different categories of eligibility for students and as we dive into the document i will just call your attention it's page four or page nine of your attachment item

[00:47:55] that highlights this new section specific to those students impacted by ongoing pandemic conditions this fall and spring and you'll notice that the proposed guidelines established two options for these students to earn their verified credit through an amended locally awarded verified credit process and the choice and option for these students depends on the subject area one and then of course the certain capacities at the local school division level and i will talk a little bit more about that in just a moment so option one applies to any subject area so it's

[00:48:30] across the board and it's a it's a pathway to getting to the um to the locally awarded verified credit via an attempt of the sol and scoring within a certain range on that sol and of course assessment and i recognize that that probably sounds pretty familiar to all of us who are who already know the labc process well and in many ways it's pretty similar but it does provide flexibility to students in two ways the first of which is responding to the board's guidelines that students attempt sol and of course assessments twice prior to accessing the locally awarded

[00:49:04] verified credit process so this would be amending that requirement and requiring the student only test once and then of course the modified score range for these students would no longer be 375 to 399 but an expanded range from 350 to 399. so again both of these things responding to the the potential of students not performing as well on these sol assessments as they may have under other conditions i will note that for this first batch of students using option one they are able to access the same modified LAVC process as was available to those students in spring and summer

[00:49:43] and if you will recall the the purpose of kind of re-establishing the LAVC process wasn't to water down rigor or create an easier process the integrity of and substance of the review process is still intact there but it's really recognizing that school divisions will probably be administering a higher volume and so it makes the pathway to administration for school divisions a little bit easier and then option two as dr lane had mentioned goes into more specificity around verified credits and history and social science and this is actually available only to those divisions that are able

[00:50:20] to administer local performance assessments and history and social science so for these students who are seeking a verified credit in history and social science and the school division has the capacity to administer local performance assessments there is no requirement to attempt the associated sol but the pathway to the locally awarded verified credit must include local performance of tasks tasks that are graded by state rubrics and and including the state rubric component we're really kind of guaranteeing a consistency and process across the state because local school divisions will be able to reverse engineer their tasks based on our

[00:50:59] expectations that are set out in those state rubrics. Again as Dr. Lane mentioned and a little bit of context for the second option during the 2020 general assembly session the legislators did pass budget language that allowed us to use local performance assessments in history and social science where this had formerly been prohibited. So option two not only provides us a little bit of flexibility for our students

but it really encourages our local school divisions to start thinking about building capacity and local performance assessments and encourages them to do so by allowing them to use this flexibility in the fall of 2020 as well as the spring of 2021.

[00:51:38] So I will quickly note that that is kind of one of the distinct differences between option one and option two as well. That option two flexibility would extend into spring 2021 and noting that there will be a small technical amendment to the final version of the document that carries that spring 2021 language throughout the entirety of option two so if you notice that is missing in that that section of the document that will be corrected before the final version so and again as dr lane mentioned this is contingent on board approval here but these guidelines will need to be accompanied by a waiver which we will be sending over to the secretary's office assuming

[00:52:17] the board is comfortable with the proposed emergency guidelines here today so with that i I am happy to take any questions you all have about the guidelines themselves or the associated waivers. - And Mr. Gecker, I'll just add one final comment, if I may.

[00:52:34] - Please, yeah. - I think it's important to note board members, I think this is assumed, but just to be said directly, we are not canceling the SOLs in these areas. The school division still have the option to deliver the SOLs for their in-person students or for their virtual students.

[00:52:51] These are just alternate pathways by which students can earn a locally awarded verified credit. All right, are there any questions? - I have a question, maybe a little clarity, clarification for Dr. Sayle. Thanks very much for the overview, but I do have a question.

[00:53:11] I think one of the last things I heard you say or acknowledge was the use of state rubrics for scoring, but I heard you use a phrase that it would allow, and I may be paraphrasing inaccurately, so that's why I'm looking for clarification. It would allow divisions to reverse engineer their tasks, and then I'm adding to meet the rubric is what I think I heard that sounds or could be perceived as teaching to the test.

[00:53:37] And I don't know that that's what we intend. So I just wanna make sure I'm really clear on what the purpose of the rubric is, how we anticipate it will be used and that the use of that rubric in the awarding of locally verified credits and/or performance-based assessments is not, would not be implemented in a way that we would not expect it to be.

[00:54:05] You know what I mean? We're trying to get a clear view of what students know and are able to do. Reverse engineering doesn't necessarily speak to that to me. So I just need some clarification. - Sure, well, and I appreciate you bringing up that comment 'cause that certainly wasn't my intent that this would translate to teaching to the tests.

[00:54:25] But what really effectively I meant is that the state rubrics will clearly set expectations for our local performance assessments. That's not specific content or specific in terms of what we are expecting the students to produce in terms of kind of content and evidence and demonstration of mastery as it takes shape, that will be kind of an individualized project towards the students.

[00:54:51] So it's not necessarily allowing the school divisions to create a task that will intuitively make sure that they meet all of the requirements of the rubric, but really ensuring that local school divisions are developing something that has consistent rigor and adequate demonstration of mastery across the board.

[00:55:09] And I will certainly open it up to Shelly and the history and social science team as well, if they have anything additional to add in that space, since they're much more well-versed and intimately familiar with the local performance assessment option.

[00:55:25] - Thanks, that's very helpful. I just wanted to hear it articulated because I think the turn of phrase could be taken out of context and we need to be really clear about what we mean. - Absolutely. And I appreciate you requesting the clarity and giving me the opportunity to communicate that as well.

[00:55:46] - President Gecker. - Dr. Duran and then I guess Ms. Holton. - Oh, Ms. Holton was first. - No, no, go ahead, Dr. Duran. - Okay, please. No question, just wanna thank Dr. Sale and Dr. Lane for this flexibility that I think is much needed. So that school divisions can really make sure that we are understanding what our students' needs are, but at the same time balancing that with what is happening currently in our situation now.

[00:56:09] And so I know school divisions across the Commonwealth really want to make sure that we're understanding where our students are via assessment, but doing it in a way that I think is meaningful. And of course, I have to put a plug in for the work of previously serving this innovation committee and the issues there that were raised around performance based assessments as being a more meaningful way, I believe, of understanding mastery in social science and science.

[00:56:35] and that was a recommendation that committee put forth so just having as an aside on that but with the flexibility here and clearly clearly Dr. Sell and Dr. Lane the thinking here and the work that you've done to put this forward is going to benefit many many teachers many students as well as school divisions so thank you for that. I'd like to echo those sentiments too because when Dr. Lane and Dr. Myers and myself toured a couple of school divisions in southwest Virginia the locally awarded verified credits were on every superintendent's mind and that's something that they kept bringing up in all of our discussions was was this need so thank you

[00:57:14] Dr. Lane, Dr. Sale for putting putting those needs first. Ms. Halton. Yes thank you uh not a question just to come and I just I heard an interview recently with a Harvard school prof former uh secretary of education in massachusetts and he used a phrase of thinking about our schools in in the time of covet as you know we're still pulling people out of the rubble of an earth

[00:57:48] holton i think we have lost at least the video and i can't hear any audio mass is it just me who lost the audio there or is it everybody so i just uh turned off my video Does that help on the audio? Very much so, yes, thank you. Okay, thank you.

[00:58:17] Just briefly, I heard an interview recently with Paul Revell, who's a Harvard Ed School prof and former Secretary of Education in Massachusetts, referring to our current schools, the schools in the time of COVID as we're still pulling people out of the rubble of an earthquake. And I would add that the rumblings the aftershocks are even still happening uh and anything we can do by way of giving our divisions some relief you know it eventually need to get back on track on our accountability system but temporary measures that give more flexibility i'm all for across the board

[00:58:56] we're we're in uh we're in earthquake mode yeah anybody else have any comments or questions let me just ask how long do the waivers uh how long are they good for so i apologize did i speak over someone no no okay um so the this particular waiver itself um the the actual shelf life of the waiver um would end the year 20 or the june 2021 so the end of the school year um but because the

[00:59:32] application of lavcs may extend until the student needs to graduate we have a note in the additional consideration section of this document to to remind school divisions to make sure that they have this notated either in a student's record or in their individual policies to make sure that this translates and carries through with the student till graduation so while the the waiver and the flexibility wouldn't extend that far it will just assure that students that that did have access and were eligible for these flexibilities will continue to have them through graduation

[01:00:06] okay and do we believe that is does staff believe and uh you know you dr sale and dr lane that the policies sort of of the waiver that is to go to performance-based assessment is something that we ought to be doing long term which i think is where the board has been but uh just want to make sure i understand what's going on here i'll take that one dr sale uh in these two subject areas yes right now that's what we're talking about specifically thank you james okay anybody else i don't see

[01:00:41] anybody? Is there a motion to waive first review and adopt the emergency guidelines? So moved. Thank you, Dr. Mann. Is there a second? Second. Thank you, Ms. Davis-Vaught. Again, by roll call, Dr. Mann? Aye. Ms. Holton? Aye. Dr. Wilson? Aye. Ms. Davis-Vaught? Aye. Dr. Durand? Aye.

[01:01:08] Dr. Pexton? Aye. And I vote aye. Thank you all very much. Thank you. Okay, item H, final review of recommended cut scores for the grades three to eight and end of course standards of learning reading tests based on the 2017 english standards uh yes we've had a request i note here for perhaps a short break i don't know if you'd may like to get through this item and then before we get to uh the others but just putting that out there thank you uh honestly uh if people want to break them you know content taking a break uh is that sort of the desire

[01:01:46] just sort of a nod yes or no yeah okay we'll do a uh how about a you know 10 minute or get i guess five minute break i'll be back at 1105. thank you pam for telling me what to say

[01:02:01] oh dear okay i make it to be 1105 um see is everybody back emily see dr pexton she was just

[01:07:53] up there. I think she may have pulled her video down, but she was back just a minute ago. There she is. I'm missing anybody. I feel like, remember those old Where's Waldo books? It's like, where's my board book here? Okay, I think we have everybody. Yes, we are good. I'm always counting to make sure we have seven. That's what I'm doing. Okay, we will move on then to item H, final review of

[01:08:28] recommended cut scores for grades three to eight, et cetera. Ms. Loving Ryder. - Good morning, President Gecker, members of the board and Dr. Lane. Today, I am bringing to you for final review, recommended cut scores for the grades three through eight and of course, standards of learning test based on the 2017 English standards.

[01:08:52] As a reminder, we did develop new reading tests last year that were to have been administered in the spring of 2020. And you all actually received this item on first review almost a year ago in January of 2020.

[01:09:10] And it was to have come before you for final review in March. Of course, with the pandemic, your board meeting was canceled and we also canceled spring 2020 testing. These tests will be scheduled for administration in spring of 2021.

[01:09:30] it is necessary for you to adopt cut scores on the test because they do represent new content based on the 2017 english standards and president gacker and normally i would not go through a great

deal of detail in a in final review but since it's been almost a year since you entertained this item with your permission i will review the standard setting process briefly yeah that's fine Ms. Loving Ryder, although I will tell you I remember it like it was yesterday.

[01:10:00] Okay. All right. So this is a fairly complex and technical process. So I did provide you with some information about the process we use and it is included in attachment A. And this is the process we have really used since the beginning of the SOL program and it is very much a teacher driven process but the description standard setting really is a systematic way of making a professional judgment based on the level of achievement required for students to reach a

[01:10:36] specific performance level and in Virginia in reading for three through eight we have four performance levels advanced proficient basic and below basic and then for end of course we just tab three: advanced, proficient, and fail. This is a very much an educator-driven process.

[01:11:00] We bring together committees of teachers for each test and then they are trained on the standard setting process by psychometricians. And psychometricians are really statisticians that their specialty is testing. So the training really begins with teachers reviewing what are called the performance level descriptors and I provided an example of a performance level descriptor for you in attachment A and this really describes what students are to know and be able to

[01:11:36] do for each of the performance levels and these are developed by teachers and approved by committees of teachers. So once the committees go through the performance level descriptors for their particular grade level then they spend a considerable amount of time thinking about of those performance level descriptors what are the skills and knowledge that a student would need to demonstrate to be just over the line so just barely proficient or just barely advanced and they create descriptions

[01:12:10] of what that would mean following that discussion teachers actually begin to review the actual test items and so keeping in mind what is requiring those performance level descriptors they review each item and make a judgment as to whether a student who will use proficient as an example who is barely proficient would get that item correct and they continue that process for all of the performance levels so advanced and basic each teacher makes an independent judgment and then

[01:12:51] those uh the judgments are aggregated to create a cut score and really the the cut score is an aggregation of the yeses so the number of items the teacher said would be necessary for the student to get correct to be to be proficient and that is described as round one at the end of round one teachers on the committee are provided with information about how the other panelists viewed the items so they've given information about what the cut scores for the other committee members

[01:13:25] were and then they also spend quite a bit of time talking about specific items where they disagree so someone might say that this item a student should get it correct to be proficient other committee members may have felt that the student would not need to get it correct after that discussion the committee members then go into what's called round two and they they make the same judgment review each item and determine whether or not they think a barely proficient student should get that item correct at the end of round two they're again provided information

[01:14:03] about what the other panelists felt and they they discuss items where they're they're still having discrepancies and then round three teachers are given a final opportunity to review their cut scores based on all they've heard and make any adjustments they think are necessary and so that that judgment

represents what is called the round three judgment of the of the committee after all of the individual committees have met so an individual committee for each test grades

[01:14:40] three through eight and of course then we have an additional committee that we refer to as the articulation committee that committee is comprised of three members of each of the individual committees and they meet on the final day of standard setting to review the recommendations of the individual committees with the added information of estimated impact datum so they also have information about the estimated number of students who would fall into each performance level and really their job is to determine whether or not the cut scores recommended by the individual

[01:15:20] committees are reasonable based on the impact data and also the performance level descriptors and their their recommendations are also provided to you for your consideration you will note as we get to the recommendations that the articulation committee often does recommend a change from what the individual committees recommended and so all of this information is provided to you and then it is your responsibility to make a final judgment about what the cut score should be for

[01:15:57] the various performance levels and all of this information is included in attachment B and I And I think Emily is going to pull that up for me so that we can all see it and we can talk through what's here.

[01:16:12] So attachment B actually has two pages. The first page provides information about the past proficient and past advanced cut score. And then the second page has information about basic. But I'm going to actually go over the first page as an example.

[01:16:31] So for each test you will see that there's information provided for you regarding the past proficient and past advanced on this first page. And for each performance level I've provided you with background information and then the standard setting summary and that's where the recommendations are.

[01:16:53] So I'm going to just go through briefly using grade three as an example of the information we've provided here. So under background information, the first column provides you with information about what the cut score was previously.

[01:17:10] So on the history tests that were based on the 2010 standards, the cut score was 25 out of 40. The second column that says pass proficient cut score for a new test to maintain previous level of rigor provides you with an estimate of what the cut score would be on the new if you required the same level of achievement as you required on the old test, and you'll notice

[01:17:39] that here the cut score that would represent that same level of proficiency is again the 25 out of 40. So that's the background information, the old cut score, and then an estimate of what the cut score would be on the new test if you maintain the same level of rigor. Following the background information there's the standard settings summary in the first column under the standard setting summary gives you the round three median for proficient this is the recommendation of the

[01:18:19] individual grade three committee the median is just the middle score of the range of panelist recommendations and then the the second column gives you the articulation recommendation so you'll notice in this particular case that the recommendation of the individual grade three committee was 16 out of 40 items were sufficient articulation committee felt that this was too low and so their recommendation is 21 out of 40. and then the final column is the superintendent's

[01:18:57] recommendation and this is where dr lane has reviewed the information and made a recommendation as to what he believes the cut score should be and he certainly does that in consultation with staff at the department and you'll notice here that he's recommended uh 22 out of 40 moving the the recommendation of the articulation committee up one you will notice that 22 out of 40 is still well below the 25 out of 40 which would maintain the same level of proficiency as what was required

[01:19:32] on the old test the same information is provided for pass advanced and the basic cut score on the next page and then for each test so mr gecker would you like for me to read the superintendent's recommendation at this point or would you prefer to have discussion first i think the superintendent's recommendation now then we'll have discussion if that's okay surely sure and the superintendent's recommendation is a bit lengthy. Okay, the Superintendent of Public Instruction recommends

[01:20:12] that the Board of Education approve scale scores of at least 400 for past proficient and at least 500 for past advanced. The grades three through eight and end of course SOL reading test based on the 2017 English SOL. These scale scores shall be equivalent to the following number of items on the test forms reviewed by the educator committees convened for standard vetting grade 3 22 out of 40

[01:20:44] for past proficient and 35 out of 40 for past advanced grade 4 reading 23 out of 40 for past proficient and 35 out of 40 for past advanced grade 5 reading 24 out of 40 for past proficient and 36 out of 40 for pass advanced. Grade 6 reading 26 out of 45 for pass proficient and 39 out of 45 for pass advanced. Grade 7 reading 26 out of 45 for pass proficient and 39

[01:21:17] out of 45 for pass advanced. Grade 8 reading 26 out of 45 for pass proficient and 39 out of 45 for past advanced and of course reading 24 out of 47 for past proficient and 38 out of 47 for past advanced because the minimum scale scores for the failed basic achievement level for the grades 3 through 8 sol reading test will be specific to each test the superintendent of public instruction recommends that the board adopt cut scores based on the following number of items correct

[01:21:54] on the test forms reviewed by the educator committees convened for standard setting. Scale scores that represent the same level of achievement shall be determined once the board adopts the cut scores for each test. Grade 3 reading, 10 items correct.

[01:22:11] Grade 4 reading, 12 items correct. Grade 5 reading, 11 items correct. Grade 6 reading, 12 items correct. Grade 7 reading, 13 items correct. in grade 8 reading 12 items correct and i'd be happy to answer any questions okay are there any questions at this time thank you uh miss lovingrider um i have a question yeah dr wilson thank you um miss lovingrider thank you very much for that overview and the

[01:22:46] refresher course on standard setting um when we as a board when we looked at this as first review it was january certainly pre-covid and pandemic i wonder if um miss lovingrider or dr lane if there's been any consideration um knowing uh i certainly understand that the cut scores will be set for uh some period of time beyond just this year however given the instance dr lane as you described are being in virtual settings moving back to virtual settings from being in person in

[01:23:22] a number of divisions whether or not that has any bearing on the recommendation that we are being asked to consider today. Kelly, I'll take that if you want. Okay. We did discuss that and what we determined is that the level of proficiency that we would expect at grade level should not change based on the circumstances and we think that that would set a precedent for the future that could be concerning that other circumstances that we don't know could come up and we'd be

[01:24:01] constantly looking at revising the cut scores based on circumstances and so for that reason we decided not to make a change in recommendation that said and this will sound somewhat counter to this should the board go with a lower cut score than we're recommending rather than the higher that we are recommending we would want you to take some time next year after the results come out to make sure we didn't get way off calibrating how that would look.

[01:24:35] President Gecker, if I may add, the Board of course does have the authority to adjust the cut scores as needed. So while you are adopting them today, as Dr. Lane mentioned, should you feel that an adjustment is necessary in the future, you do have the authority to do that.

[01:24:52] I appreciate that. If it's okay, Francisco, let me just ask one thing here before we get to you. The purpose of the cut score, and I guess of all of this, is to determine sort of where our children are in terms of academic performance and have they met the minimally proficient level defined as what they ought to know, I guess, and just a little bit more.

[01:25:22] You know, we have used, I guess, the modified Angolf method for a lot of years to determine, yeah, Jamel's smiling, but when my kids ask me later on today what I did today, I will say I engaged in a discussion of the modified Angolf method with some amount of pride. So we've used that for a while. And, you know, actually back when this first came up, we did a little bit of, I did a little bit of research to see, you know, what people thought of the validity of that method for determining cut scores, how accurate it was.

[01:25:55] And frankly, it seems uniformly that the modified hangoff method that we use is considered to be in the communities that matter an appropriate and sound methodology. And really that method would stop with the articulation committee and typically not go on to a superintendent or higher authority.

[01:26:20] There's studies out of Korea on the pharmaceutical industry using this and all that. You know, and I know James has said before, and probably correctly, that if we, you know, set a higher cut score, we might actually improve results. There is some literature that suggests that if you set the bar a little bit higher, but attainable, you might get some better results overall. But you would also then label some children as failing, who actually are, in fact, minimally proficient, according to, if you believe the, you know, articulation committee measure you know according to the sort of scientifically derived cut score measure I guess

[01:27:01] you know what I'm struggling with here and frankly I'm not struggling with the idea of using the articulation committee recommendation I'm struggling with the idea of why the department believes and I'm sure there's good reason for this that when we actually see the results we might make changes that is make it seem like it's you know it ought to be harder if we believe in the validity of the underlying process that set the goals in the first place in other words do we never want to get to be a point where we measure ourselves as being better uh is it always going to be a certain percentage you know have to fail in order for us to believe that the measure is that

[01:27:41] set at an appropriate level well i i'll i'll take that uh question thank you um i do think that any educator in our schools would tell you that 100 of our students are not proficient as of today And I think there's a point at where you could set the cut score so low that it would mask the needs that our students have.

[01:28:09] I'm not saying that that's what would happen here between one point between articulation and superintendent's recommendation. But I do think that there's a touch of common sense that plays into our thinking around, well, it can't be too low because we know that we have struggling readers in the Commonwealth.

[01:28:32] The other thing I would say is, whereas the modified engulf, and it is modified, right? I mean, we talked about that, but the modified engulf is primarily driven by Virginia educators considering a Virginia standard. We do face national comparisons on a regular basis, and we know that in recent history, our national comparisons have not been favorable, and we believe that in part is because the cut score was too high the last time.

[01:29:02] so we do believe bringing it down is appropriate because I think we were over identifying students that needed support and so we're trying to hone in on where we are between the national standard, the articulation standard, the previous standard and we weighed all of that in our decision making but you are correct we have also looked at the research that supports you know that if our state standards bar is is higher and by higher i mean closer to the national standard but not all the way at the national standard because i do think that that is an aspirational standard uh i think

[01:29:41] that it could uh in turn lead to better instruction for our students now the other thing i'd say about is uh uh we also did this with you know the review committees articulation committee you could you have to understand that there's standard error there if you did five different articulation committees you might get five different recommendations you if you did five different standard setting committees you get different recommendations and so whereas it is an appropriate

[01:30:17] method uh and and from you know we're we're not we're not in a potential where we could replicate this as we would in a normal research world over and over again and to reduce that standard error there is flexibility in determining that standard I guess if you had if you believe in the standard error piece although again most of the studies you read say you're within about three percent no matter who does the uh you know how many committees you have uh you would expect some of them then to be high and some to be low within that range and yet the superintendent's recommendation

[01:30:50] is all assuming that the articulation committee is low well and keep in mind uh you know articulation is one group standard setting is many uh and standard setting was far lower in every case and so um i don't know that you might not have seen variability in articulation had that been replicated in a formal research study i guess what bothers me about this is the idea that we're going to set the number based upon the result we think we ought to see and you know either

[01:31:30] we change our process for setting you know or we accept our process which we've used for a long time and again having used it for a long time doesn't mean it's good it just means we've used it for a long time but unless there's a reason to believe that the process is wrong you know i i really don't and you know i understand the education piece that if you set the bar higher maybe you'll teach a little bit better and maybe you'll have some better results here or there you know what we're telling people this is for is to measure minimum proficiency and you know not to use it as the you know raise the bar and thereby increase quality piece

[01:32:10] uh so i mean i struggle with it but i know i've talked too much about this dr duran i know you wanted to speak and then dr mann if that's okay well mr gecker may i please respond to that first do you mind yeah um well and and i i i don't think we're setting this with an intention of where we hope the

outcomes lie we're setting this with an intention of improving students abilities and and i there's a distinction there between the two uh to me um but i i i i do feel like

[01:32:41] um it's it's important uh it's important that we not set proficiency such that we're not identifying struggling readers so that we can provide the academic interventions that would be necessary but wouldn't we do that with the formative tests i mean isn't this one too late to say we're using this to identify to improve individual students i mean at some point it seems like the you know horses out of the barn at this stage you know i would much prefer us and we've talked about this before you know see us use formative assessments during the year uh and

[01:33:19] find a way to incentivize divisions to use those in a more uh thoughtful and i'm not saying they don't do it so this comment ought not be misread because honestly i don't know exactly how it's used in all the divisions and i'm sure in arlington they're used perfectly but the you you know this is really a product of sort of a different goal than helping individual students right the sols the assessments entirely end up being uh you know for accreditation as opposed to for individual student advancement and so i'm just not seeing it but you know we don't have to

[01:33:55] have this debate because i know you see this differently than i do and that's okay but i don't see this as a teaching tool as much as I see it as potentially being punitive or if the system we use to determine the score is wrong we ought to be fixing that system you know you could but anyway Francisco well Mr. President as you know I have an amendment so I don't know if you want me to do that now or wait until Dr. this is your time Francisco well I would like thank you and it's It was good to follow you on your comments.

[01:34:30] So I would like to bring forward an amendment to align the cut scores to the articulation committee. I do believe strongly that this is a teacher-driven process as Ms. Livingrider shared. I really appreciated Ms. Livingrider you telling us the detail about the training that goes into place, the individual review that each of the three rounds with regards to understanding whether students know and are able to do each of the performance level descriptors.

[01:34:56] I think the articulation committee at the end when they really finally review and weigh that is really important. And to your point, Mr. President Gecker, for me as an educator, for me assessment should really be around, I do think it can inform teaching practices and I do think it should be used that way if it is aligned in a way to what our real true assessment of whether students are mastering the concepts and the learning outcomes are being met at each of those indicators.

[01:35:23] and it's a balance that I think that with the process we have I think we could improve the process but given the process that we do have and honoring the teacher-driven process that we have had in place with that deep review and Ms. Lovingrider in your presentation you did not in any way share that that you felt that the process was not done well this year I think you reiterated at a pre in a year ago and when I asked you that this was done very well and you and I asked if you had confidence in all of the rounds and you said you did.

[01:35:53] And so given that and given the notion of where we are with the articulation committee and the final judgment is what your word you use, Ms. Loving Ryder, after looking at the cut scores and balancing them with the reasonable performance level objectives, I'm putting forward a motion, Mr. President, to have the cut scores aligned to the articulation committee.

[01:36:16] - Okay, we have a motion. We'll go to a second, if that's okay, and then we'll come back to discussion. - I'd like to second that motion from Dr. Duran. - Thank you, Ms. Davis-Vaught. Okay, now we're back to discussion. - President Gecker? - Yes, Dr. Mann. - I just wanted to reiterate a couple of points because I actually, you spoke to something that I was going to speak to, and it really did have more to do with the fact that the tests happen well after students are at the end of an academic year as opposed to really being used in ways to shape instruction.

[01:36:50] And that's not to say that schools can't use this information to evaluate instructional practices and what might need to happen to address learning needs.

[01:37:00] But I do think that's a really important point. And I think the other thing that for me is a challenge, I believe in high bars, but I struggle so much with what I know about schools that are serving students who are challenged and we have high bars and we can't staff those schools because people are not signing up in droves to go and work.

[01:37:35] in environments where students are struggling. And I think thinking about the content of the condition of education that we adopted today, I want to believe that setting a high bar is going to mean education will get better. I just worry that students who are in schools where they don't have access to high quality teaching, I don't see that faring so well for those students. And if

[01:38:13] If the purpose of these particular assessments are intended to focus on proficiency as the basis and the process certainly was described very, very clearly. I do appreciate the revisit of it.

[01:38:29] There's still dimensions of subjectivity to it, but that's not a discussion that we need to have. have, but I think that's a sticking point for me that I know I am struggling with when I think about the inequitable access to teachers that are prepared to support students that need the most support. It's really hard to add another dimension of challenge to trying

[01:39:05] move the needle on shifting that reality that's a challenge for me okay anybody else i'll just make uh i just want to respond to one of the things that you said mr gecker sure i fully recognize uh the way this vote is going and please know we'll support whatever the board decides as all as always but uh teachers teachers do use the sol as as a as a benchmark for their instruction the the benchmarks that school divisions create the more formative assessments that they create

[01:39:44] are aligned to the standard that you set and by setting a standard at the end that filters all through the school year with the bar that that that teachers will teach to i do struggle with the notion of of lowering the bar and the expectation for students because we feel like students in certain settings are not getting quality teachers at this time i think that should drive teacher quality more than the standard but i wouldn't want you to vote on this thinking that the SOL is not a major factor. What we see historically in the SOL is that over a seven-year

[01:40:20] period that we deliver this SOL, teacher and student performance gets better every year as they learn the assessment more, which shows us that instruction is adjusting based on the bar that you set and and i think that's that's a really important point and uh um and so uh i i think that uh what what we see in the field is that that adjustment over time is important but what you saw in this last sol and i think this is important as if as you do go towards the articulation committee what we saw in this last so well is that we did not see student performance improve over the last

[01:41:00] seven years which told us that the last standard that was set was too high and so i think it's important to note that whether you take my score or for our dr dron's recommendation either both of those are a lowering of the standard of what we saw seven years ago and with that we look forward to implementing the cut scores as approved by the board let me just make one quick comment to make sure because you said you were responding to me but i think you responded both to me and to dr man i also believe that we ought to change the bar based upon the teaching environment or the school environment i think the idea here is not to set a high bar or a low bar but to set the bar that

[01:41:39] actually is measuring what it is we want students to know you know one might say the correct bar and to me if you have a process that says you know here's how we're going to find the correct bar for minimum proficiency that's the bar you ought to be using uh for all students regardless again of circumstance you know the idea though that the test score is increasing indicates that teaching is getting better doesn't necessarily follow for me I mean frankly I think test scores increase because people learn what subset of the material is going to be tested and therefore as

[01:42:15] they get used to and understand more about what's going to be on the test it's easier to teach to that test and so it's natural that you're going to see a rise in test scores you know again we can debate this a lot uh but i don't think that as i said the the test scores themselves or the the tests themselves ought to be used as you know the raise the bar kind of teaching technique you know as we discovered as we did the work in our comprehensive work program dealing with

[01:42:49] equity and teachers was going to change our outcomes as our teachers and almost everything else with the exception perhaps of building leadership you know faith just is small that impact is small in comparison to improving uh the quality of teaching in individual classrooms and the support we give our teachers so anyway we have motion we have a second is there any other discussion on this yeah mr gecker can i chime in just to say just to say that uh uh i am supportive

[01:43:24] of the motion and for the reasons articulated by Dr. Duran and by you, President Gecker, and I'll just add that two things. I'll add that I think the principle ought to be when we have a system that we respect and we think has worked well here, we ought to stick with the system that means the articulation committee, unless there's a good reason to deviate, unless we have a really strong reason to deviate from it and i've heard i've heard and i appreciate dr lane's perspective and and others but i haven't heard something that's a really strong reason

[01:44:01] why we should deviate from our process i don't feel like i have the expertise that the articulation committee has and unless i have some really strong reason i'm i'm inclined to go with that My other point would just be that I'm really more interested in the discussions that we're going to be, I hope, looking forward to having under Dr. Pexton's guidance on the SOA committee about growth measures and how we can help our teachers, help our system more and more be using high quality formative assessments that really help focus on growth.

[01:44:40] And that's really where we need to head. This train needs to head how we can use these tests or other assessment methods to move the system more to growth basis. And so for those reasons, I would support Dr. Duran's motion.

[01:44:56] Okay. We have a motion and a second. I will not make Dr. Duran say it in the full way that Ms. Loving Ryder did. But I think we understand we're voting on whether to adopt the articulation committee recommendations or cut scores. Dr. Mann, I think you're muted.

[01:45:17] Yep, aye. Okay, Ms. Holton? Aye to the amendment and to pass the item as amended, if that's what the vote is. That is what the motion is, thanks. Dr. Wilson? Aye. Ms. Davis-Vaugh?

[01:45:33] Aye. Dr. Durand? Aye. Dr. Pexton? Aye. Chair votes aye. Thank you all very much. Ms. Loving-Rider, thank you so much for the very clear explanation of this. we certainly appreciate it and for your you know expertise in this area and James I would be remiss too I mean although we may disagree on certain items I and I think the board always appreciates the quality of your input to these discussions and respects your opinion greatly so you know

[01:46:05] thank you for chiming in so much okay the poor folks from Covington and Allegheny have been you know I guess held captive on this zoom call for a long time but we are now finally up to item I thank you all for being so patient you know we've been watching you guys on the screen and know that none of you have dozed off yet so I guess this starts with Dr. Sale yes hello Dr.

[01:46:37] Gecker and another good morning to President Gecker Vice President Wilson Dr. Lane and members of the board i am very pleased to present to you and i guess i should say rather set the stage for you um an item that has actually a few precedents um for the board of education and i believe it's a first for for myself and and the members of the the current board so and this is the item regarding the consolidation of allegheny county public schools and covington city schools so as you As you all know, I am joined today by some of the Division's consolidation team who will

[01:47:10] provide momentarily some more details and case for consolidation, but as you guys probably detected from the proposal that they've shared with us today, prior to submission, this consolidation team undertook quite a process of discovery, really looking at feasibility of consolidation as well as its pros and cons.

[01:47:32] And from this work, which you will of course hear more about, was the conclusion that a consolidated school division would be better able to meet the standards of quality as well as serve its school community better than the existing school divisions could separately.

[01:47:48] Before handing over the stage, I will quickly share that the basis of this consolidation proposal is found in section 22.1-25 of the Code of Virginia, which does allow local school boards to submit a proposal for the consolidation of school divisions to the board of education for consideration and the joint proposal that we have here today has met all of the relevant prerequisite conditions for submission and provides the board with the criteria required for consideration of such a proposal i will note one quick update to the information provided in

[01:48:23] your board boilerplates at the time that we drafted this and submitted it to you all for review The re-enrolled version of House Bill 5005, which is the budget bill for the 2020 special session, had not been yet released. And as of yesterday, Governor Northam has signed HB 5005, which does restore funding for consolidation efforts in the second year of the biennium. So just an asterisk on that piece of information from your boilerplate. And with that, I would like to invite Jacob Wright of the allegheny county school board jonathan errett of the covington city school board and

[01:49:01] stephen pipe grass of trotman pepper hamilton sanders to continue the presentation well thank you um good morning uh president gecker vice president wilson members of the board and dr lane it's uh an honor to present this uh proposal to you all we very much appreciate the attention that that you all are paying to this important issue for these two localities in Virginia and I also

[01:49:34] want to thank Dr. Sale, Ms. Webb, staff for all the support that they've provided over the last weeks and months as we've as we've gone through this this process. I think as you'll see as you read the written submission and hear from the members of the joint committee this morning, a lot of time and effort research um and expert consulting has all gone into this um to to really deeply study this uh this proposal um and make sure it really is the right next step for the

[01:50:12] communities involved um if you could move to the next slide please i'll introduce the folks who will be speaking this morning so um we've divided up the pictures on the screen in front of you um into the the three of us who are presenting uh the bulk of the presentation and this particularly the substance of it will be um presented by the co-chairs jacob wright and jonathan errett jacob is with the allegheny county school board and jonathan is with the

[01:50:48] covington city school board um on the second row you'll see uh folks who we've labeled as advisors who are also present um those are folks who are all on the on the phone on the zoom call available to answer questions from you all and i think it really demonstrates the the cross-section of the community and community leaders that have been engaged in this process you've got superintendent of allegheny county schools sherman callahan covington city school superintendent melinda

[01:51:22] Sneed Johnson, County Administrator John Lanford, City Manager Crystal Oneidas, and then Jim Reginbaugh with Fiscal Analytics who I know you all know who played a really great role in in preparing the feasibility study that kicked this process off. The bottom row of folks are I'm sure all watching on YouTube. They're not joining on on this call in a participatory manner but they certainly participated a great deal in preparing all the materials that have been presented served

[01:51:59] on various subcommittees and we're all part of the joint committee on school consolidation so you've got allegheny county school board member gerald franson covington city school board member eric erica hunter allegheny county board of supervisors matt garten allegheny county board of supervisors also james griffith mayor seibold from the city of covington and then alan tucker from covington city council so again we very much appreciate all the hard work all of these folks have put into

[01:52:34] to uh preparing us uh for where we are today um with those introductions i'm going to turn this over to uh jacob and jonathan to walk through most of these pieces but i will chime back in when it comes to the uh the the legal the legal questions and uh taking off the various boxes that you all need to look at um in in considering this um from the perspective of the virginia code so jacob and jonathan why don't you take it away from here all right thank you all very much president gecker vice president wilson uh to the rest of the board members i'm jacob wright i'm the

[01:53:09] co-chair of the um joint schools consolidation committee and uh i'm also the chairman of the allegheny county school board our first slide is the proposed consolidated division the following plan is the culmination of over 50 meetings of our committees our plan calls for the july 1st 2022 merger of our central offices with a merger of student populations happening one year later on july 1st 2023 on july 1st 2022 our central offices will be merged and governed by a seven member board

[01:53:45] comprised of four members from Allegheny County and three members from the City of Covington. While the board member amounts are not even, a two-thirds majority will be required for the hiring and firing of a superintendent as well as the construction or closure of schools.

[01:54:02] Our superintendent and assistant superintendent will be chosen from the current superintendents from our two systems. On July 1, 2023, our joint high school will be housed at the current Allegheny High School and our joint middle school will be housed at the current Covington High School. All four of our current elementary schools will be retained and our two middle schools will be repurposed. Next slide please. The Allegheny County School Division is currently made up of

[01:54:39] Allegheny High School, Clifton Middle School, Callahan Elementary School, Mountain View Elementary School and Sharon Elementary School. Our end of the year membership was 1909 students. The Allegheny High School campus is also home to our jointly run Career and Technical Center that is currently run by Covington City Public Schools and Allegheny County Public Schools jointly. The center was a collaboration built in the 1960s by Allegheny County, the City of Covington and what was then

[01:55:14] the city of Clifton Forge. Nearby the AHS campus we also have the Jackson River Governor's School on the campus of Dabney S. Lancaster and that is a joint school joint program between Covington, Allegheny, Bath, Rockbridge and Botetourt systems. Next slide please. Mr. Errett. Thank you very much Mr. Wright, President Gecker, members of the board, thank you for for having us. I'm Jonathan Errett covington city school board for our division in the city the covington city schools is comprised

[01:55:54] of covington high school jeter watson intermediate school and edgemont primary school with covington high school serving grades 8 through 12 jeter watson grades 4 through 7 and edgemont primary pre-k through third grade our end of year membership for 2019 2020 was 995 and the city's estimated school age population is 957 and we have officially been operating as an independent school division since 1958. Covington and Allegheny County have experienced a steady decline in both

[01:56:33] population and school enrollment since at least the early 1970s. While both divisions currently enjoy relatively low student to teacher ratios, recent school closures in the county and the and the continuation of economic and population decline in the city have highlighted the difficulty that communities face in properly supporting small rural school divisions.

[01:56:54] We believe the consolidation of Allegheny County and Covington City Public Schools will be in the interests of the students by providing additional course offerings, electives and activities. As Mr. Wright mentioned, an equal opportunity for the city and county students to attend Jackson River Technical Center located on the AHS campus currently, and possibilities for greater partnerships with the Ebeneus Lancaster Community College that are currently not available or practical.

[01:57:22] We also believe that accreditation and SOQ concerns will be better met with the combining of area resources to provide for the new division. Next slide, please. - All right, the history of consolidation efforts.

[01:57:37] The two localities have been discussing consolidation since shortly after they divided in 1958. Allegheny County and the city of Clifton Forge, the then city of Clifton Forge, consolidated in 1982. There was talk at that time of Covington City Public Schools being a part of that consolidation, but it was not supported by the Covington City Council.

[01:58:01] Over the past eight years, we've had several meetings to discuss consolidation to no avail until 2018 when the county school board penned a letter to the three other bodies that resulted in a committee now known as the Joint School Services Committee.

[01:58:19] The committee is comprised of two members of each of the two school boards, the City Council and the Allegheny County Board of Supervisors. This committee and this effort have received legislative support in the form of initial budget allocation of $400,000 by the General Assembly to study the idea of a consolidated school system.

[01:58:39] The funding from the General Assembly has been instrumental in getting us to where we are today. Next slide, please. Mr. Pete Grass. So, in considering this proposal, the board is mandated to take into account the various factors under 22.1-25 of the Code of Virginia.

[01:59:06] The first two factors here, consent of the school boards and consent of the governing bodies, has been met. You will have in the written submissions the resolutions passed by both school boards and both governing bodies. governing bodies supporting consolidation.

[01:59:23] The other criteria here are listed and some have already been addressed and others will be addressed in this presentation and all are addressed in the written submission as well. The declining school population is one of the drivers here by bringing the student body populations that he believes that they'll be able to better serve those students and bring even better resources to bear right size student teacher ratios, et cetera.

[01:59:55] The potential to facilitate offering of a comprehensive K to 12 program. Again, there are a couple of schools that have accreditation, but with an asterisk, we believe those can be addressed through this consolidation as well, bringing everyone up to the highest standards of quality.

[02:00:16] We've looked at efficiencies of school operation. Mr. Reginball is available for questions on that, but we do think over a period of time, we could see a savings of up to $900,000 annually, just due to consolidating central staff and right-sizing in various areas.

[02:00:39] Obviously the population is something we've addressed, relationship of geography and topography to transportation. There's a transportation study that we undertook and we'll address that later in the presentation. And then I've mentioned the standards of quality.

[02:00:57] Next slide, please. In your packages, in the packages that were submitted, is the supporting information and data for each of these different criteria, the cost savings. Right now, the transfer of title questions are still to be resolved.

[02:01:19] But we've got the current plan is for localities retain titles until their governing bodies uh decide otherwise um at the end of this presentation there will be a a slide showing the anticipated timeline for next steps um and the and the procedures that will go into into bringing about the consolidation um the plan for school board representation has been addressed as was mentioned this would be a a body made up uh for three of county and city representatives a lot of time and discussion and consideration went into that

[02:01:57] determination and it's it's reflective of the populations of both and given that two-third majority vote requirement for important decisions I think both sides are satisfied that everyone will be fairly represented finally with respect to evidence of local support this is not a decision anyone takes lightly. Academic and policy studies about school consolidation have all recognized that consolidation is an issue of where there are high emotions and many different factors,

[02:02:33] including local loyalties and athletics, etc. And so it was never to be expected that an overwhelming majority in any area would support consolidation nonetheless 54 of those polled support consolidation among these two localities and about 38 opposed and once additional education is provided on the issue of the benefits of consolidation we see those numbers increase

[02:03:08] when it comes to the support uh as well so again this is an area where i think we've we've met the statute statutory criteria as well next slide please thank you mr peepgrass um the foundation of our committee's work was provided uh as mr peepgrass mentioned by james reginbaugh and dr richard salman and their feasibility study completed in december of 2019. following the completion of the study our committee divided itself into subcommittees comprised of committee

[02:03:44] members themselves school administrators local officials and subject matter experts from around the area the finance governance facilities transportation and curriculum subcommittees all released memorandums that when combined with the transportation study the public poll conducted by 2020 insight and the aforementioned feasibility study comprised the total body of work behind our presentation to you this morning. Next slide, please, Mr. Wright. All right. Proposals, benefits to students. The most important benefit to our students in a merge system is enhanced

[02:04:22] course offerings and more schedule flexibility. By combining our two middle schools and our two high schools, we will be able to offer access to greater schedule flexibility and access to more elective courses. One jointly run high school at the Allegheny High School campus also offers better access to our on-campus career and technical center covington high school students now have to be bused to the jackson river technical center the proximity of the high school to dabney s lancaster community college also offers expanding expanded offerings and partnerships with the

[02:04:58] college dabney s lancaster community college is also interested in expanding their offerings into what is now currently the county's middle school next slide please all right um as mr wright touched on we do believe this consolidation will result in greater efficiency of use of our existing school facilities from both a classroom and central office space standpoint our larger pool of staff will help ensure our lower student to teacher ratios can be maintained for longer with less fiscal stress the use of an early retirement incentive program will help right

[02:05:37] size the new division staffing levels over time and free up resources to offset the expected increase in expenditures will likely see from the equalization of salary and benefits between the two divisions staff. Support from the governing bodies as was mentioned and their school boards was made official in September of this year when all four bodies passed resolutions authorizing this consolidation. Equally important the public support is present throughout the area and as Mr.

[02:06:08] Peepgrass touched on, the evidence of support appears to go up when more is learned about the proposal itself. Next slide, please. The existing transportation capacity should be sufficient from day one of the new division with some modifications to current routes and schedules.

[02:06:30] Some travel times will increase, but others will decrease, offsetting additional expense and easing planning concerns the respective localities as mr peepgrass mentioned previously will retain title to school property unless other arrangements are negotiated the existing debt service from the individual school boards will be transferred to their respective locality for retirement the repurposing of vacated middle school space will be determined by the consolidated school board and the governing bodies but as mr wright mentioned there is local interest and opportunity

[02:07:05] for repurposing that the timeline going back to that briefly we believe does allow ample time for us to continue to plan and prepare with our central offices again scheduled to combine july 1 2022 and the student bodies joining one year later in 2023 2024 school year next slide please mr peter so if if the board and we understand this is first review and we will of course come back for final review and take into account any questions or comments that come up

[02:07:45] between those those two meetings but if approved we would be working with the delegation on support measures from the general assembly we've already engaged from the very beginning of the process with with that and the results as you saw and as Dr. Sale mentioned include the additional support in the second year of the biennium um that that we just found about this morning um so again that i think reflects the uh the support at all levels um that this proposal uh has um some minor adjustments to the city charter will need to be made to reflect the

[02:08:25] consolidated divisions um really a procedural issue um then the uh the new members of the consolidated board would be appointed um you've got july 1st 22 2022 uh being the effective date for consolidation of the divisions and boards um appointment of the uh the new superintendent and assistant superintendent uh policies uh manual policy manual adopted and then the the merger of the student bodies would take place um for the 2023-2024 school year um so those would be the

[02:09:02] major next steps coming out of the next meeting um next slide so again we very much appreciate all of the uh the time and attention that the board has paid to this uh this important proposal and um the the great support that we've had from staff that i think has really improved and helped crystallize our thinking in many areas and we're happy to answer any questions that you all may have uh as are the other folks who i mentioned at the beginning who are on this call um but weren't

[02:09:36] uh weren't providing this this presentation for the sake of time um so again thank you very much for for all of your attention and your support thanks to all of you uh thanks to everybody who's with us on this on this item are there any questions by board members and president gecker if i may really quickly before we of course of course thanks to our friends that are listening in over at the house appropriations committee um did want to note a correction around the budget item and hoping not not and dashing any hopes of of our our panelists and and presenters

[02:10:13] here um but that that money does remain on unrestored um in the current budget it was just hidden in the back of the budget um so i apologize for for miss misstating there um and we'll can certainly answer any questions that you might have about that but as as far as we understand it the board item as is does stand around funding um thank you if i may thank you dr dr sale for for that additional update um that and that is something we we have been working on with with uh the folks here in richmond um and it i think it is it's something that we'll continue

[02:10:50] working on on the legislative side and that initial placeholder was really meant to show the support coming from the legislature we understand the exigencies created by coronavirus has played havoc with everyone's budgets but we'll continue we will continue to work on that so thanks for that update and thank you Mr. Pipegrass for for clarifying I appreciate your your understanding on that one all right any questions by board members Ms. Davis-Vaugh thank you for that presentation and my question is I don't I'm not exactly sure who to direct the question to I'm

[02:11:27] very curious about your presentation as far as i'd like for you to go a little bit more to the grassroots of the situation i'd like to know um the the buildings the age of the buildings i'd like to know um

i hear about the support that you have for the consolidation of the schools but i i do know from the public comments that there there are some questions and some comments from the population so um let's hear the other side of the story about what are the major concerns from the people who might not be in full support of this consolidation and I'd like to know um what what are

[02:12:03] some of the specific ways that you're going to handle the consolidation of the central offices is it attrition is it retirement is it um how how are you dealing with those changes specifically how are you dealing with those teachers is there going to be a great job loss is there has there is there going to be some unemployment are we going to have teacher movement so back up just a tad bit and give me a little bit more detail as to to why this consolidation is um moving forward um yes yes ma'am uh miss davis vod i appreciate your question

[02:12:40] um i'll try to address them i think as you uh as you were asking from the opposition standpoint let's say um i think we saw here locally very much what you see when you study consolidation all throughout the country which is for us here in the city of covington being the smaller of the two localities the smaller of the two school divisions a lot of our population very much was fearful of that loss of local identity that you always hear about everything from you

[02:13:15] know the athletics you know extra participation opportunities for some children in certain cases and that's just a logistics two teams versus one team type thing uh and then uh culminating i believe or at least crystallizing in uh covington high school's building that facility was built in the 1940s and and is culturally a very important building to us here in the city of covington so we had a lot of concerns i think from local residents about that but to to boil it down to

[02:13:51] its simplest element i honestly believe it is that loss of local identity and when we first began this i was doing as much research as i could and that really wasn't a tangible idea i could put my hands on about loss of local identity but the further we got through this um it is it is something it's very hard to for people to put their finger on uh you know and and uh as as mr peepgrass alluded to earlier I think it's it's rooted in just sentimentality and the emotional aspects of any time you engage in talks like this and then you were talking about the age of the buildings

[02:14:30] throughout the region I know we we are blessed to have two fairly recent constructed buildings in the current Jeter Watson and Edgemont schools here in the city and then the county in 2000 I believe constructed there combination clifton middle school and mountain view elementary school and so allegheny high school i believe was constructed in the 1960s but we talked at length in our first visit to richmond and met with folks in dr lane's office and

[02:15:06] really any anyone we could to provide insight and we are blessed to have facilities that have been well maintained and would be adequate for our combined student population you may have to to refresh me on some of the subsequent questions there. I'm sorry. Well, thank you. That describes the buildings there. So what's the economic situation there? Is this a high, excuse my ignorance, but I do not know what your economic disadvantage percentages are. Is this a high poverty area? Do you have vulnerable populations? Tell me more about the demographics there of the

[02:15:44] area? I can answer I think the first part of that and I would defer maybe to our county administrator and city manager for anything deeper on the economic level. The two school divisions currently operate at roughly the same percentage of disadvantaged students by I suppose it would be the federal government's measure and I believe that percentage is in the low 40s percentile I I believe, Mr.

Wright, if you remember that off the top of your head, I think we're in the 43% to 44% range of students qualifying for free or reduced lunch, for example.

[02:16:24] Any other deeper economic measures, I would defer to county administrator and city manager for that. One more follow-up, if I may, sir. with the plans to close your two middle school and use your two current high schools as your two functioning secondaries, is there any plan to do any updates to those buildings moving forward?

[02:16:51] We certainly would like to, although as I'm sure you're aware, obtaining additional revenue for capital expenditures is sometimes difficult. And that's one of the reasons, I think, if you were to poll most of the folks that are proponents of this idea, the combining of local economic horsepower, I think is something that everyone sees as a benefit across the board up to and including when we start to upgrade any of these older facilities that we have, yes, ma'am.

[02:17:29] - Okay, any other questions at this point? - Thank you, Dr. Wilson. - Thank you, Mr. Ehret and Mr. Wright for being here and for your presentation. Just one question, and perhaps it goes to the two superintendents, maybe a little bit of what we anticipate the impact to be on teaching and learning with the consolidation of the two divisions.

[02:17:52] How will we, what do you envision that process looking like and then the outcomes longer term? - Thank you for the opportunity to speak today. Melinda C. Johnson, Superintendent of Covington City Public Schools and both school divisions have always had academic excellence as their goal and have worked hard to provide Melinda C. an outstanding education for our students. And that is the goal of this combined school division is to offer more opportunities to our students.

[02:18:25] And we believe the curriculum committee has been working very hard to structure out a plan for moving the curriculums from we currently have. And we're really very similar, but there are some differences and it's a very active committee and curriculum is always looking at the academic outcomes for our students as we move forward into a new school division.

[02:18:48] So I think that is a positive outcome of this endeavor. - And if I may, I think touches on both questions. The question just asked, and then circling back to a question Ms. Davis Vaught asked about the teachers, the teaching environment, and are we planning on right-sizing the new division through attrition?

[02:19:14] And the answer is yes. That's the plan is to basically combine the two divisions and then over a period of years, both with an early retirement incentive program that the new school board could craft to be mutually beneficial, both to the faculty members themselves, and then also, you know, in that effort to right-size the new division.

[02:19:36] We're very optimistic. And I think some of Mr. Regimbalm and Dr. Salmon's work had reinforced the point that we do have an opportunity with some additional support to right-size the current division staffing levels through attrition.

[02:19:58] - Okay, any of the members of the board, Ms. Halston? - Yes, thank you. I just wanna commend you all for your hard work. I just, it really, I'm just overwhelmed with gratitude to the hard work that the whole committee has done, but especially the school boards and superintendents.

[02:20:19] I recognize this is not easy. And to put the needs of your students above your own personal interests. And absolutely in the long run will be great for your collective communities, but it's just never easy consolidations as you've seen from the history of how this has come and gone over the years.

[02:20:50] But to recognize the tough work you all have done and come up with what to me seems like a very, very strong proposal and a plan for how to do it effectively a way that's going to benefit your students both in the short term in terms of more academic offerings but in the long term in terms of stronger fiscal health for all. I can't say more strongly how impressed I am at your hard work and that you've managed to continue that in the midst of a pandemic. Wow. I'll just say one final thing which is if and when this is all

[02:21:25] finalized i hope you do channel those savings into further academic excellence whether it be addressing building issues or or other educational opportunities for your students all i am convinced that all of our divisions and i'm looking at you all's numbers are underfunded uh still and and the state needs to do more on that and maybe there will be other support coming from other resources over the longer hall but local localities also have the opportunity and i hope you uh i hope your plan is to channel the savings back into education um and i thank you again for your work mr gecker

[02:22:03] this is jim reginwall can i add a little color to this discussion uh i don't know but you can try well i would like to add that the post school divisions have similar demographics have similar sol results we found low dropout rates they have very similar lcis so in that sense it does make it simpler for a consolidation because they're similar in a lot of ways and i appreciate that anybody else from the board i don't see one more follow-up about the grade level configuration

[02:22:38] of the new proposed high school 8 through 12 is that what i heard no man go ahead jacob i'm sorry we're looking at six seven and eight for the combined middle school and nine through 12 for the high school and one of the things that uh i did want to touch on is the idea that uh a lot of these are we try to base all of our uh findings on facts and one of our things is the uh our current high school the allegheny high school has a larger capacity than the covington high school so it's more fitting to have four grades there than it is to have uh have them at covington high school okay

[02:23:17] thank you sir thank you uh miss need johnson did you come off mute to speak yes sir and i hope i answered everyone's questions uh so if i didn't answer them correctly i'd love to have a second chance i know i sometimes need to rethink my thoughts but were there any questions from any of the board members about what we plan to do and why we plan to do it in our area and i echo with melinda sorry i got i lost connection for about 15 minutes uh configured right when it got to our

[02:23:54] part but uh same thing for allegheny county if anybody needs uh any verification on some of the questions you all had be happy to answer what i can no we appreciate both of you i don't see anybody right now with any more questions mr peepgrass i assume you've done the requisite public hearings yes we have mr president okay i didn't see that in the documentation but i'm sure you did i'm sure it's there too i just missed it yep those were in order to get those resolutions passed we had to have hearings and then we had many many many opportunities for public comment through

[02:24:31] those 50 meetings that were mentioned as well so now i get that although i thought the code specifically referred to and maybe i'm wrong yes uh before you file here you need to have a public hearing yes we did okay and if if that doesn't appear in a very clear manner in our in what we presented we can you know when we uh send you all that final that final version we can we can make actually the burden is on

you more than on us frankly so you don't need to clarify i mean it's clear that you got a lot of public input from the presentation but it was not clear to me that

[02:25:04] you'd done the requisite public hearing post you know resolution and pre-filing so all right uh the board i think is happy to accept this on first review mr becker before you move forward i'm i - I apologize, but I just wanted to acknowledge Ms. Snead-Johnson and Mr. Callahan's question about if we had any other questions.

[02:25:28] My specific question around teaching and learning really was getting to, I think the work that Ms. Snead-Johnson acknowledged the curriculum committee. And so I will be interested as this process moves forward to understand how we are ensuring that quality education continues as you both are already doing in your individual divisions, but that commitment and those resources and the attention continues to be paid even in whatever the outcome of this whole process is.

[02:26:04] So that was the root of my question and we'll certainly be interested as the process moves forward to hear more about that. And we'll be curious to see how children are affected by the work that you all are doing, not just by the access to additional coursework, but the outcomes at the end of the day.

[02:26:24] So thank you very much for acknowledging that. - You just asked, just 'cause that triggered something. What happens if the assembly doesn't give you the money you're looking for? - That's an excellent question, President Gecker. And I think our plan B, if you will, would probably be to simply idle the plan until the proper amount of state support could be secured.

[02:26:54] Depending upon, I mean, we all have sort of envisioned different scenarios of levels of support that could be obtained. And if there is nothing there, I think that our option quite simply would be to idle because we've all acknowledged throughout the process that the equalization of salary and benefits is a, it was a central tenant when we began this, and to overcome that fiscally, we will need additional state support.

[02:27:23] If the levels of support are fractional, let's say, you know, we can always look to additional funding sources, but as I'm sure you can imagine, those are not plentiful. So we would simply look for the most support we could, but obviously we hope that the General Assembly would be able to provide that.

[02:27:43] I appreciate that direct answer. And I guess I would like to understand at some point, and it can be offline, Susan Williams, our lawyer, is what happens if we vote to consolidate and then you idle the plan?

[02:28:01] I'm not quite sure what occurs there. We're scheduled back in January. We will not know, I guess, the results of the funding issue at that point. - Right, we will not know.

[02:28:16] That's correct. I mean, I guess we could try to address it resolution, but ultimately the Board of Education, you know, would have to act by resolution to basically dissolve the two separate school divisions and create a consolidated school division. No, I guess what I'm asking is what if we vote in January to consolidate and they then say no, we're not going to do it because we don't have the funding. President Gecker, could we have a delayed enactment of the... I don't know. Listen, we don't need to kill this issue online, you know, know, right now, but I would like at least, you know, our lawyers and your lawyers and

[02:28:56] the people engaged in this to at least think that through and decide whether January is the appropriate time to come back. I will say, I think I can read the board fairly well after doing this for a while. I don't think the board has any issue with the consolidation. I mean, I don't think this is going to be a close vote. I hope I'm not, I rarely speak in front of an actual vote, but just be clear where i think we are so that there's no agitation on your part on the other hand i i am

[02:29:30] very curious if we do this i mean i guess it's done and i'm not sure how you undo it if you know you decide to idle and susan uh like i said perhaps you and mr peepgrass can discuss this i'm not excluding by the way anybody else on the call from that but just as the logical places to start with the lawyers uh and let us know if january is the right answer or frankly if you would do it regardless of funding from the assembly that would be helpful to know i don't want to create a circumstance that we can't really undo right you know easily uh if you decide to

[02:30:06] not go forward for any reason and i'll be happy happy to work with anyone um you know we we appreciate it and appreciate the concern and i'll be happy to talk with with ms williams offline as well and um we we meet very very regularly as a group with the folks who are working on this um and it's it's something where we are tracking closely so happy to engage on that with you all good well thank you very much i think that covers this and did you want to say something uh you came back on so i didn't know okay all right then uh thank you all very much it's very

[02:30:44] interesting uh you know we appreciate your bringing it and as miss holton said you know it's really uh comforting and encouraging in a lot of ways to see people working together in this fashion in these times and you know it's very it's a very good thing so thank you all very much thank you all so much for your time okay uh before we move on to item j i would like to point out that of our article 8 section 5 responsibilities we have covered item b in that the annual report

[02:31:22] we have covered items item c in that approving the list of superintendents and item a includes you know the division and consolidation of school divisions so if we were playing constitutional bingo we would have a b and c kicked off on our cards already today which is actually pretty cool But also, you know, they referred to Section 22.1-25, which is the provision the General Assembly put in the criteria for division of school divisions, you know, most of which come

[02:32:00] out of a Senate report that was done in 1971, actually from the '71 session, but published in '73. There was some talk at the legislative briefing and a question asked about, I guess, in response to the recent VCU report that came out dealing with the division of divisions, if you will, and the equity issues surrounding the division of divisions. The question was, how would they implement the ability to do, you know, divisions in order to provide a greater

[02:32:36] socioeconomic mix? And, you know, one of the answers is that if you look at that same code section and as was mentioned today uh the greatest restriction on us as our board to do that is the requirement that each of the school boards and the governing bodies in the jurisdictions actually weigh in on that issue uh positively before we can do it and that's before that's a condition before you get to the criteria that they went through in item c uh we've been asked to provide

[02:33:11] I've been asked to provide some thoughts as to what criteria we would add or amend in order to allow for the board to, you know, consolidate or divide based upon other criteria than the ones listed here to, you know, perhaps achieve a greater socioeconomic mix among our divisions. And I throw that

out there. I'm not looking for a lot of discussion today, but you ought to be aware that that issue is you know coming to the fore uh and at least a few of the

[02:33:47] senators who are on that call are looking to promote that uh through the current session so uh that's just a point of information we will move on to item j first review of emergency guidelines for the use of local performance assessment to verify credits in writing for 2021 miss loving writer morning again mr gecker i know that we are running short on time so i will try to do this item quickly no ma'am we scheduled a full day for these meetings and if we need to take it we will take it

[02:34:20] okay give us what we need uh no more no less if that's okay fine um so i am bringing to you for first review emergency guidelines for the use of uh local performance assessments to verify credits in writing for this school year. And as Dr. Lane mentioned in his comments, this is another opportunity to provide additional flexibility to school divisions related to the COVID-19 pandemic.

[02:34:49] This particular flexibility is not dependent on a waiver. It is just an expansion of your guidelines for this school year. Just as a reminder, the 2017 Standards of Accreditation allow the opportunity for school divisions to verify a credit in writing using a local performance assessment that is compliant with the guidelines that you approve and you all did approve guidelines in 2018 for school divisions who choose to exercise this option as a reminder those guidelines

[02:35:25] require the collection of three writing samples representing each of the modes of writing that are required at the high school level that is argumentative analytic and persuasive and those writing samples have to be scored by people who are trained in the rubric and they have to be completed at school the body of evidence is then reviewed by a panel of educators and just a

[02:35:59] determination is made as to whether that student should receive a verified credit so the the purpose of the guidelines that are before you today are to provide some additional flexibility for school divisions who have chosen to exercise this option during the the pandemic in 2020-2021 and those guidelines are included in attachment a and you will note that they are presented as strikethrough and underlined version of the 2018 guidelines and before i go on mr gecker i did

[02:36:34] want to acknowledge the work of staff in both assessment and instruction in revising these guidelines. It was done on a very quick timeline and they represent a lot of work that was done outside of office hours. So I did want to acknowledge the work of those staff members.

[02:36:52] As I mentioned earlier, the intent is to provide additional flexibility and the flexibility is as follows. It would allow the students to prepare one of the writing samples in a virtual environment.

[02:37:09] There is some opportunity for two of the three writing samples to be developed in a virtual environment if the school division was not able to collect a sample in spring of 2020. The additional flexibility has to do with the required scoring of the writing samples.

[02:37:29] normally we require that someone other than the student's teacher score the writing sample for this year under these guidelines the proposal is that the student's teacher could serve as a score but we have included language that highly recommends the use of an additional score if the student's teacher is one of the scores the idea that there is a collection of evidence that must be reviewed prior to the student receiving a verified credit stands and that panel would

[02:38:06] include educators who have been trained in the rubric and it would not include the student's teachers so just to reiterate the flexibility is the potential for one or perhaps two of the student writing samples to be completed in a virtual environment and the second flexibility is in regard to who may score the student sample and the flexibility here would be to allow um for this year for the the student's teacher to be one of the the scores and um the superintendent's

[02:38:42] recommendation is that you approve these guidelines um so that they can be implemented quickly and so that school divisions can uh incorporate the additional flexibility and i'll be happy to answer any questions mr gecker hey are there thank you very much ms loving writer uh are there any questions at this time no questions just thank ms living writer and as she indicated all the staff who worked very hard on this i want to greatly appreciate all their extra efforts to provide this flexibility for our school divisions thank you thank you mr gecker yes ma'am just a comment

[02:39:22] I appreciate the strongly recommend language regarding having a second set of eyes to the writing, to the assessment. That I think is a valuable recommendation, certainly recognizing that in all instances it may not be possible, but I think it does send a signal, a message, about the importance of having multiple folks um have a look at a student assessment uh performance

[02:39:57] assessment in this way so thank you for that okay is there a motion here so moved to waive first review and approve the emergency guide will be approved yes yes thank you dr duran is there a second i missed that dr man yes thank you very much all right uh any other discussion seeing none

[02:40:23] Dr. Mann? Aye. Ms. Holton? Aye. Dr. Wilson? Aye. Ms. Davis Vaught? Aye. Dr. Duran? Aye. Dr. Paxton? Aye. And I vote aye.

[02:40:38] Thank you all very much there. Brings us to, I guess, Kay? Mr. Gecker, this is me as well. Yes, I know. I've got it. Thank you. Okay, so this is today I'm bringing to you for first review emergency guidelines for the use of local alternative assessments in lieu of the Virginia studies civics and economics and grade 8 writing standards of learning tests for the 2020-2021 school year. This is another effort to provide additional flexibility for school divisions

[02:41:14] during the pandemic and this one is dependent on the approval of a waiver as Dr. Lane noted in his earlier comments. So really in response to the issues of the pandemic, Dr. Lane has pursued a waiver to allow school divisions flexibility to administer local alternative assessments in lieu of the Virginia studies, civics and economics and grade eight writing test for the 2020-2021 school year. And as Dr. Lane noted, these are tests that are not required by federal law.

[02:41:51] so the state does have additional flexibility and so what we have before you today is a set of emergency guidelines that would provide guidance to school divisions who who choose to implement this option as Dr. Lane noted earlier this does not mean that we're canceling the standards of learning assessments for these content areas that would remain an option for school divisions who choose to to pursue that but for those who do wish to administer a local alternative assessment they would need to comply with these guidelines again the requirement would be that they use the

[02:42:31] the rubrics the state developed rubrics that we have provided and they would also need to report on the progress of students as part of the regular regular reporting that is being required of them Again, I would like to recognize staff from assessment and the humanities area of instruction for their work on these guidelines.

[02:42:55] Again, these were done in a very quick timeline and represent a lot of work outside of work hours. So, Mr. Gacker, I think your superintendent's recommendation here is that UA first review and approve these emergency guidelines for the use of local alternative assessments in in lieu of the Virginia study, civics and economics and grade eight writing standards of learning tests for the 2020-2021 school year.

[02:43:23] - Thank you, Ms. Loving-Ryder. Are there any comments or questions on this? - Just to reiterate our thanks again for the staff that worked on this aspect. Since I did on the last item, I don't want to neglect the staff who worked on this item as well. Thank you, Ms. Loving-Ryder, for everyone who worked extra hours to put this in place.

[02:43:41] Appreciate it. - Yes, thank you. Anybody else? If not, is there a motion to waive first review and adopt these guidelines? - So moved. - Dr. Duran, seconded by Dr. Mann. Any other discussion?

[02:43:56] Seeing none, again by roll call, Dr. Mann? - Aye. - Ms. Holton? - Aye. - Dr. Wilson? - Aye. - Ms. Davis Vaught? - Aye. - Dr. Duran? - Aye. - Dr. Pexton? - Aye. - And I will vote aye.

[02:44:13] Thank you, Ms. Loving Ryder, and thanks to the staff. I would say you guys are just like articulation committee just right thank you very much we appreciate it all right item l first review of revised foundation blocks for learning ah miss conway i hadn't seen you before welcome i hope we haven't kept you too long oh no glad to be here glad to see everybody i think we're now in afternoon so i will say good afternoon to everybody um and i'm very excited i think it's one of the first

[02:44:48] time for bringing me something for review rather than update. And I think that's a positive sign of what's to come. So it's great to see everybody. I also wanted to introduce Erin Carroll from our team, the Director of Early Childhood, and Tamela Richardson, our Associate Director, who have done an incredible amount of work getting us to this place. Next slide, please.

[02:45:11] Today we are very excited to bring you a comprehensive guidance document that would replace the foundation blocks for learning which are primarily used now with four-year-olds we'll talk about how we see this resource helping us improve school readiness in the commonwealth we'll go into detail on how we have through both in terms of our process as well as achieving more equitable outcomes think this can be a tool for increasing equity in the commonwealth and early childhood we'll make sure you understand the process for development and then i'll give you a high level overview of the of the early learning development standards and then last but not least

[02:45:51] a quick review of where we go from here in terms of implementing these this resource next slide please one more emily so you've heard me talk about this before but fundamentally we are building a division in office of school readiness and office of early childhood that is focused on ensuring that every child in the commonwealth has the opportunity to enter kindergarten ready we know from the data we looked at last year that nearly 40 percent 44 percent of our kids are entering

[02:46:26] without that opportunity when we look at literacy math social emotional sort of self-regulation and social skills we also know that right now things like demographics predict outcomes so when we look at our children with special needs when we look at english language learners when we look at kids from economically disadvantaged backgrounds that they are more likely to come to school without the full opportunity that all of their peers do and we have to tackle that systematically across all of the programs

that make up our early childhood sector family child care child care and centers head start pre-k in the school and we are working very closely with this board

[02:47:04] thanks to legislation passed to address this these standards which talk specifically about what kids should know and be able to do and i should say kids collectively infants toddlers and preschoolers are really a first step in addressing this next slide please what we have what we're presenting for review today is the guidance document that really helps us understand what infants toddlers three and four year olds know and should be able to do these are different from other resources that you might see because they go beyond one particular subject so you'll see it's a very

[02:47:38] dense document it covers everything from social skills and sort of gross and fine motor to things like the arts, literacy, language, communication, math, science. It is intended to show development as a spectrum and in doing so it kind of provides a comprehensive view of what we want for infants, toddlers, and preschoolers in the Commonwealth. It also then serves as sort of functionally to replace a set of different documents and also to align with what's used nationally. So this would replace the foundation block for early childhood learning it would replace what was produced

[02:48:16] previously by the department of social services that we also kind of reviewed the board several years ago the milestones of child development we have made sure that it aligns with what head start uses the early learning outcomes framework and we are we'll talk about kind of rolling it out and this will be different from foundations which is really focused on the video preschool initiative but this ultimately would be a resource as we take responsibility for unification of the system that we could use across our publicly funded classrooms across all settings so it's really kind of a first of its kind in terms of a board reviewing a guidance document that we use in

[02:48:53] child care we would use in family child care homes we would use in schools as well as in head start programs wanted to frame you're going to talk a little a bit about process And again, Kamal and Erin have helped lead this in combination with our incredible partners at Regina Commonwealth University who worked with stakeholders across the state.

[02:49:15] The process is really important. So each state has its own kind of birth to five standards or some version and it's really important that you do that in a way with the community, with the stakeholders, with practitioners. This is particularly important for us at this point in time as we take on a broader scope as a board of education and department of education i also think we're very cognizant of this board's effort around equity and cultural responsiveness and so that as you'll see that was a key guiding principle as we go forward again we also want these to be very useful right there's all you could say there's a lot more spraying science and developmental information

[02:49:52] than we know now but if it's not usable by a family child care educator a head start educator or school-based educator then it really won't help drive better outcomes and so that was a key principle for us we have a special emphasis on equity and i'll talk more about that with the idea that this should be a tool that's useful for the educators and families that are most vulnerable kids and we wanted to make sure that this fully prepares you for coming to our k-12 system and so making sure it's in alignment with what you expect when you enter kindergarten or kindergarten sol so let me take a couple minutes to focus deeply on equity and i know mr gecker and others

[02:50:28] this has been a real important sort of of chief importance for you all as we've talked about before, and I won't go through each of these slides, but we continue to gather evidence from Virginia and

across the country and really to hone in on where there are disparities and equities in early childhood and how we might continually think about how we address them. Oftentimes, early childhood is thought as a real lever for opportunity, and we completely agree with that, but we still think that there are challenges both in terms of access, right, because this is a system that oftentimes you have to pay to play in right because it's not a public good for all or quality

[02:51:05] right um and so you know in terms of who has access to kind of high quality experiences that we want to tackle so as you look at this as i noted before right now too often background does predict your likelihood of coming to school ready and we have to tackle that and we have to tackle that systematically across the commonwealth next slide please in so doing this was sort of in the front of our minds as we started on this process we received some federal dollars so that preschool development grant that we applied for the resources that we used to create these standards but even as we started this and this was kind of in response to federal grants we wanted to

[02:51:43] make sure if we were doing something for virginia that it truly reflected this board's focus on equity and we thought about that both in terms of outcomes right how do we make sure we have a tool that help can help bring about more equitable outcomes but also process and so there's a couple of key things or sort of you know additional values that we imbued into every step of the process we wanted to make sure that we were addressing kind of any ways in which standards or other similar tools could be inadvertently perpetuating racism systemic racism or discrimination and really kind of to tackle that head on we wanted to make sure we sort of confronted those attitudes practices

[02:52:22] right that fundamentally the folks who participated in this process and ensuring we had the broad participation that we weren't sort of privileging one culture you know or one group over another right that we sort of we're we're fully exploring making sure we had a lot of representations and we wanted to make sure and you'll see this language explicitly in our document that we saw diversity as an asset right that we recognize that kids develop kind of not not autonomously right but in relationships with adults in family in community and that our standards

[02:52:58] feel accessible to all kids communities adults in the system and that it really treats it as an asset that it doesn't feel sort of geared towards one audience or another next slide please this talks through sort of the specific steps that we took to do this both in terms of engaging a very broad set of stakeholders really looking at different aspects of diversity race ethnicity geography rural urban provider type other demographics making sure we had full representation of those educators who serve our children with special needs or developmental delays.

[02:53:33] We actually added another round of feedback, and we'll talk more about that, because we felt we didn't have the appropriate diversity at the first cut and really wanting to make sure, working very closely with our Office of Policy and Equity and Cultural Responsiveness, Inclusivity, so kind of going back out and sort of specifically intentionally including our broader group, and we revised the draft iteratively once we heard from folks. You'll see it throughout, both in terms of the language more generally our commitment to this and then a kind of an important touch is including things like examples that are very clearly sort of representative of

[02:54:08] the diversity of our kids served in early childhood the references for instance we have a such as and we use the spanish term for aunt tiki rather than saying hey my aunt right so these little references throughout making sure that it's truly accessible to all of the audiences all of our educators who serve our

children birth to five in the commonwealth um and this is sort of again provides sort of a little bit more detail on kind of how we hope this tool will help address increasing equity and outcomes um and so again we know that our current standards our current sort

[02:54:46] of system has all these disparities but with these these revised uh this revised guidance documents that we're providing actionable culturally and developmentally appropriate guidance right a real focus on our infant and toddler educators who are more likely to you really need sort of scaffolds and supports to provide high quality developmentally appropriate guidance and support we are making sure that we are addressing the needs of all learners we are encouraging wider utilization as we think about the rollout and particularly around supporting all of our educators to use this things like developmental screening early intervention supports making sure that we are

[02:55:24] folks understand when there might be a risk of developmental delay and connecting all of our educators to support as well as empowering our educators and really recognizing throughout the document the role that families more broadly parents guardians foster parents others play in supporting their children's learning and development so it's really kind of imbued through every aspect of our our early learning development standards i'll just touch on because I think the sort of process again matters before going to the overview of kind of how we got to where we are today. I will say that and you know I talk fast and I operate fast but I will say we

[02:56:04] got delayed from our original schedule for development largely because we needed more stakeholder input. Largely because we felt like we weren't fully representative of the early childhood practitioner population and so it was a rare occasion where we got off track but it was worth it in terms of really making sure we could bring you a document that we felt was truly representative next slide please so we started with experts right really folks who could bring us the most up-to-date information about what we know about kids development from both virginia commonwealth university and james madison university we then broke into subgroups involved

[02:56:41] 10 institutes of higher education across the commonwealth and over 75 experts and so they really broke it down into each of those subgroups i talked about they met um both in sort of large groups and small groups back in the day we could meet in person and there was a lot of dynamic conversation really about what we knew what's changed since we had the prior versions of the foundation block and where we wanted to go from here we also kind of involved steps and thanks to michael and christine and others both aspects of our department of education we work closely with the kindergarten readiness program to make sure it's all aligned.

[02:57:17] We're trying to not only build a seamless birth to five pathway, but ideally connect that to early elementary, right? So you really take kids all the way through, regardless of where you're served, the name on the outside of the building or the funding source, that we take you all the way through kindergarten and help ensure a more successful early elementary experience.

[02:57:35] Next slide, please. So as I noted before, we had two opportunities. We started with one, that was our initial plan for public comment, and then we added a second one. And so we posted it first for roughly about a month this spring.

[02:57:51] We partnered with the Early Childhood Foundation to make sure we could get sort of a wide set of, yeah, the widest set of stakeholders possible, and we got more than 250 responses. And then as a result, you see we were kind of more explicit language in each area regarding cultural responsiveness.

[02:58:07] We lessened the academic language, right? I mean, the advantage of going with such incredible academic partners involving 10 institutes of higher education is they bring all their expertise. challenges and thanks to our folks in the field who let us know we were just it was too targeting right and we sort of we talked in this way amongst each other but it wasn't really accessible right to folks who may have just a high school education which is true for some of our early childhood educators we added more examples particularly less so in the kind of very concrete ways we look at literacy but when you think about and this is really exciting there's a lot about social emotional learning um in the first two areas of focus or areas of development and we needed examples right

[02:58:46] to clarify what might be different for a two-year-old as compared to a four-year-old and those such as really help make that understandable and accessible for a broader audience and then we adjusted the the sort of the expectation so i thought of the kind of conversation earlier around sort of hitting that goldilocks just right spot where you want you want to kind of have high enough expectations so that educators can understand and grasp if a child is not where they typically should be and that might be kind of a flag for you but also not have it so high that we are doing developmentally inappropriate things right and i think this is really really important

[02:59:23] kind of trying to strike that right balance and really we felt that both consulting the experts as well as putting it out there and getting the responses from the field were really important to kind of hitting that right that right balance and making some adjustments based on what the field shared with us that said emily if you go to the next slide we still um came back and said we we really want to kind of make sure that we have a group that's explicitly focused you know we thought some of the things that kind of happened over the course of the summer some of the reckoning that was happening in our sector as i know it's happening more broadly in the k-12 sector was like we still felt that the group that participated was too elite and too white in terms of the

[03:00:02] feedback and so really kind of going back and saying is this truly in the virginia of 2020 right with the kind of diversity of the kids that we currently serve in our early childhood sector truly culturally responsive and so we put out a second put it out for a second review in october of this year with a set of explicit questions about cultural competency really kind of pushing it to the pushing this the guidance back into the test in terms of is this really inclusive is this accessible. And we, as a result, we added a special section on that, right, to make it clear and sort of for folks reading it where to look for those things and then make sure that we sort

[03:00:39] of demonstrated that as a commitment. We added the key equity terms both in the beginning and the glossary, right, sort of making that explicit priority. And then as I said, sort of I gave you that example earlier throughout really inclusive language in the example so that you wouldn't feel, it wouldn't it would feel like any educator regardless of which setting you're working on you felt like this was relevant to you and to the kids that you're that you're serving so it's a lengthy document um it's actually quite useful whether you've got small kids or grandkids or others um it and if emily will go to the next slide i'll give you kind of an

[03:01:15] orientation because it's a little bit different from some other guidance documents so there's two kind of key differences to note the first as you see as i said before it's not your kind of traditional you know are you know three r's right reading you know writing and arithmetic there's foundations of play and learning there's social emotional development and then you have the kind of the more traditional communication language and literacy right we don't really think about literacy with six months old we

think about kind of communication often non-verbal communication very loud right in the middle of night on verbal communication physical development and health and then your more traditional kind of cognitive development and there are certainly areas of

[03:01:54] this as you'll see throughout where the infant column or the one-year-old column is blank because it's really we're not asking one-year-olds um to do a lot of social science work right um but we are we have expectations for four-year-olds in terms of you know some of them work in the cognitive areas it also isn't it's not as sort of tight as some of our grade bands that you see in k-12 so you'll see you've got six ranges here and there's some overlap so zero to eight months six to 14 months and so on and that's because development at this age is a spectrum and you're going to see some overlap in terms of those of those things and when to expect them and that's really important

[03:02:34] we recognize that development is very fluid at this age and it's kind of on a spectrum and so this the way of sort of getting folks to anchor around here's about when to look for this thing but if a child is not displaying it you know it may be displaying some of this at six months and some another kid and totally typical might display it at eight months right and sort of really kind of reminding the field that it's important to see development as a spectrum and that there's going to be some overlap if however you know you have a 28 month old who's maybe not meeting an expectation

[03:03:08] of early toddler that might be a flag right and so really kind of trying to kind of both recognize that development is fluid recognize that development is a spectrum but also provide discrete enough kind of um into the age band so that there's at least a flag um and sort of folks should be aware of that these are not a developmental checklist these are not a curriculum these are not an assessment however they can be really helpful in making sure that all educators regardless of which setting they work in have some sense of what their their age is what their kids should know and be able to do based on the age and again their infants their babies their

[03:03:45] toddlers to three and four year olds next slide please Emily so that's the overview of the document I can give you kind of examples of the different areas but know that it is comprehensive and that's why it's so long we really tried to make it kind of as succinct as possible recognizing again this balancing act of you want to talk about play right you want to talk about social skills and getting along with peers you want to talk about things like persistence and curiosity and creativity like those are so so important in addition to kind of you know the things that we more typically talk about the literacy the math the physical development so trying to kind of

[03:04:25] strike that right balance of enough length and sort of so to be fully comprehensive but also making it accessible that said we know as it currently stands if we were to drop that you know print that out put that on the desk or really not even the desk right they'll sort of hand it to many of our early childhood educators across the state, it's not really accessible.

[03:04:46] And so, Tamela and the team are already thinking about, when you think about equity in terms of access and being able to use this with all kids, particularly our most vulnerable kids, the implementation really matters. And so, we've got our first review now. We'll bring this for a final review, provide everything goes well in January, and then we'll really start, that's really when the rubber missed the road, in terms of helping folks use this, right?

[03:05:09] most of our educators in school standards-based education they've got right and there's a set of kind of adaptations evolutions moving from the foundation block but they they're used to using kind of

standards or some version of that this is a much bigger shift for our folks in in our kind of child care settings in our family day home setting and so when we think about how we roll this out those training materials will make sure that they're accessible i often use the description of folks learning about standards or doing training on their phone at nap time right and that is literally time that sometimes our infants and toddler teachers kind of

[03:05:48] have are able to kind of look at things like this and so you know the idea that they'll get a big binder and have time to sort of spend hours on that is not is not uh possible so we're thinking about that that'll start march and again we'll go into the fall very excited to note that we are piloting this in family day homes so kind of going to the group where we think this might be the biggest change in alexandria and certainly in a time of a lot of other challenges going on so this is really will stress test uh how we sort of think about implementation of the standards and the what we learn from that pilot will help us think about what are the sort of usable materials how do we

[03:06:26] break down this big heavy document into usable tools for all of our educators with a real focus on those educators for which this is to represent the biggest change in terms of their day-to-day practice next slide please um and this just gives you a sense of what we have tentatively in the works we sort of we know we've got to take this and distill it into bits and pieces thinking about webinars and training thinking about it sort of incorporating to all of our work and sort of across our as we sort of have more and more work with child care and family day homes using the

[03:07:02] preschool development grant and the pilots there we will develop new instructional resources um so again thinking about kind of tools and modules uh sort of taking the sort of the different areas and breaking it down into sort of to checklists and and other kind of key resources um and again really focused on some of our most vulnerable populations so looking at um in our kind of in our self-contained classrooms for kids with with special needs looking at kind of learning from alexandria and some of our other family child care programs to where a lot of this work is not in English, how we might translate and kind of make this accessible, but really making sure that we kind

[03:07:40] of have a whole suite of tools and resources to support this and that we're integrating across all of our unification work in the next year, year and a half. So with that, I believe as we go, next slide, Emily, I think that's a, we, I will not kind of go into, you've got the attachment, which is the full document, and then wanted you to know both the engagement list. So we have all of the folks who participated to kind of get a sense of that and then some of the foundational resources so i know uh dr man was sort of asked earlier had a question for me about zero to three we have sort of we both sort of cited some of those resources we participated in that critical

[03:08:19] competencies training so we didn't kind of work extensively with them but it really tried to tap into both within state resources as well as the kind of most up-to-date national resources and integrate as appropriate into this document we had to always sort of in order to get it to be somewhat reasonable you know we did have to kind of pick and choose uh some of the content but it is fully aligned with those zero to three critical competencies as well as uh the head start uh performance framework let me pause there that was a lot of information uh and moving quite a clip

[03:08:53] but let me see what questions the board members have for me are there any questions dr man i just want to commend Ms. Conway and the team. Pamela has been quite busy because I've been working

with her on another committee related to mental health consultation. So Jenna, when you know that you move fast, I had to chuckle because for sure there has been a lot of movement and a lot of activity and

[03:09:27] I was glad. I mean obviously I think this is a good this is a good thing for Virginia to be moving in this direction early learning guidelines have been a part of many states early childhood efforts for many many years and having the foundation building blocks just speak to four year olds i definitely felt was was just something that needed to change and so to see that there is now a full continuum is certainly quite important i am curious about the crosswalk

[03:10:03] with the Head Start early learning framework. And I say that because as I hear the focus around accountability and uniform measurement and I think about the level of rigor that exists within the context of another publicly funded program, naturally there's an interest in wanting to understand how we help individuals who are providing these services not feel like there's yet another dimension there's another framework when we're truly talking about a

[03:10:39] program that has had a long history of establishing outcomes for children that are served across the birth to five continuum so i i am curious i'm wondering were there a lot of uh head start grantees that participated i know the timing was challenging when i saw it come out i felt like oh a lot of folk right now are focusing on surviving COVID and I just having the bandwidth to really say I'm going to stop and dig into you know reviewing and providing substantive feedback the timing was a challenge and so I appreciate you calling that out as something you all had to go

[03:11:19] back and revisit but maybe you can tell me a little bit about you know the the type of of entities that responded um in light of the timing yep absolutely so i'll go all the way back to the beginning i mean we certainly contemplated and for for folks on the phone there is a head start early learning kind of framework it's very similar in terms of laying out the expectations and as early as there was both early head start and head start it kind of covers a similar age spectrum we actually talked with folks in the state who had participated in the development of

[03:11:55] that right to kind of understanding the process around the head start and contemplated whether you just adopt it right whether we bring that to you and say hey this is what virginia should use and there were sort of two hesitations i think one of which is um folks felt you know particularly as you is we're trying to kind of create a big tent here at the you know under the board of education at the department of education and having something that felt you know that included everybody and wasn't sort of solely sort of based on one program felt important um but we also felt like and running a process that included virginia practitioners was really important and that was

[03:12:31] something that people really said was powerful about not only the kind of the final product in terms of the head start framework but all of the the kind of national contributions that had gone into that so it felt like it was created you know by head start for head start but with the kind of know a lot of expertise so we really modeled it out at sort of after the head start process for us we then also did a kind of an explicit crosswalk and kind of really would start and we pulled a bunch of the head start content in terms of kind of anchoring in the areas and then um you know made some evolutions that kind of reflected the broader set of of practitioners so we um and then

[03:13:10] went back and sort of made sure that it was still aligned so there are slight kind of differences and i think we can share with you dr man some of the kind of the crosswalk materials but not enough at any point that it felt like it would somehow put you know a head start or early head start educator in kind

of an uncomfortable place right so basically kind of being able to say whether you're using your head start framework because that's required by the program that is you know aligned sufficiently with the Virginia kind of early learning standards that you don't need you don't really need to worry about it right or sort of vice versa was the kind of the goal there so

[03:13:47] they are generally kind of interchangeable with the understanding that our Head Start programs are required to use that learning framework but that we will we will make sure that any of the training materials are also fully accessible right and we'll think and it's a good flag for us Erin and Tamela to kind of even think about kind of some cross-referencing like so for example if we do a training you know on our play and learning is to kind of think about when we cross-reference what sort of standards are coming from the Head Start framework but you know we're confident based on

[03:14:23] the folks who participated and we'll get you the list of the Head Start grantees as well but we also had a good number of our folks from the Institutes of Higher Education participate in in the Head Start process as well. - Mr. Gecker?

[03:14:38] - Yeah, Dr. Duran. - Thank you, Ms. Conway. It's great to see I was this overwhelmed listening to it all, but it was wonderful to hear and see the real thought process that went into how do we look at our students' experiences from various perspectives.

[03:14:54] One, the instructional lens of getting them prepared for kindergarten, the cultural experiences, and really honoring those experiences that students bring. And sometimes when our students from different cultures come to the table, the beginning of their education career they're often stymied or shut down because they're not seen as honored and having brought value to their own experience at that point so i love that you are focused on that my question and so thank you and everyone who's put a lot of time into this as dr man said you you moved very quickly and you've had a sense of urgency ever since we've i've encountered you i hear it from you i see it in your presentations and just even in your

[03:15:33] spirit of how you present things you have a sense of urgency to wanting to make a difference for all of our students across the commonwealth this framework i think will really help us my question is around the beyond the last slide you talked about was using this beyond and having the webinar and training of course is going to be critical to for awareness and developing capacity and the resources but how do you really i see you as a visionary i see you as someone who thinks forward how do you really envision that you will know and we will know as a commonwealth where this is happening well how do we support um places where it's not happening well i think it's great

[03:16:09] to create a framework and have the resources but i worry about the inequity of places that don't really engage in that and don't really take advantage of that or maybe don't know how to so what is your vision beyond this in terms of how we would see consistency of the use of these guidelines in action across the commonwealth that is a great question and And I think our kind of effort at a pilot is probably the best sort of direction, right?

[03:16:42] Where you, you know, I think we will sort of, I'm not going to say we're going to worry less about our school-based classrooms, right? But we're going to sort of hone in and say, you know, where will this represent the biggest change for educators, right? And it's a pretty big shift if you think about family child care.

[03:17:00] And if you think about particularly what family child care is going through right now, right? So again, these are our smaller, sort of fewer than 12 kids located in home programs across the Commonwealth. We know that they've been our lifeline over the last 10 months. I've talked with this group before about how they're remaining open.

[03:17:16] And we also know that like, you know, much of how they operate is different from how K-12 typically operates. I spent, you know, three hours on Saturday morning because that's literally, they only can do evenings or Saturdays. Like the rest of the week, like they are providing core care and education and they don't have substitutes, right?

[03:17:33] Like they are the building operator, the janitor, the teacher, right, and everything else in between. And so, like, that's a perfect example. Like if you schedule, you know, a Thursday meeting with them, like you're not going to be able to get them right there. And so really kind of recognizing the practical reality of their circumstances.

[03:17:52] I think also recognizing the diversity, right, both in terms of linguistic diversity. I think recognizing that these folks traditionally have less of a kind of a traditional education prep background, right, and sort of really addressing like what are the usable tools, like how do you distill, like no part of me thinks just sort of giving this document or emailing it out or even sharing it with the Family Child Care Association, whatever kind of accomplished that.

[03:18:19] So I think we'll look at, you know, we'll sort of, we'll, we'll focus in on that group, right, is if we, if we can figure out the tools that work with that set of educators, they're probably broadly applicable to the others. So we'll look at kind of, you know, uptake there. I think we will kind of measure the results of pilots. I think we'll work closely with our preschool development grant folks to sort of say, let's take these materials and get a sense of, of the, are they being used first right i think asking people what's you know useful or not i think getting out there and kind of looking kind of getting into classrooms will kind of give us some indicator of that

[03:18:59] and that will dr duran be our focus right because again if we don't see them being used there if we don't see um you know if we don't hear from our family day home educators that they're useful and we ask kind of our surveys for pbj if we talk with our associations and our other groups and they say these are just too much right or they're just hard to understand or they don't feel real that's a that's the kind of canary in the coal mine in terms of we've got you know more work to do on tools and resources so really kind of working with that group really through our largely through the preschool development grant that federal grant to kind of measure how well it goes with that group

[03:19:38] and then using the kind of the lessons learned from that to think about you know how those are applicable to the broader set of educators thank you for that and i'm really excited to learn more about and see how this really is in development and as i said oftentimes there's a lot of great work that we do but it's about how it actually starts to be implemented and used in our school systems and in our classrooms and in our providers in this case as well so that to me is where the rubber meets the road and i look forward to how this can really be something that all students have access to and i just want to lastly comment i appreciate what you left when you ended your presentation with with the notion of continuing to work with experts for our students with special

[03:20:18] populations and you highlighted multilingual learners for students that are learning english in the beginning phases and i hope that my vision would be that all our students are fully bilingual and learn

both because there's so much research behind that in particular at this age is a great time to start and we see this happening in many other communities across the u.s and certainly across the world where they have multilingual bilingual trilingual uh starting at this age so that to me would be wonderful for us to look at some pilots about what we might do in virginia to help begin students at this very young age starting to learn other languages because there's

[03:20:52] so much that we know about the cognitive benefit of that for their lifelong learning so thank you anybody else not well i have another question sorry dr durian we will come back also we are scheduled next spring to talk with you about our first ideas on the dessert for the practice year for the uniform measurement and improvement system and you're probably going to hear us talk as much about the supports for improvement as the measurement and so a lot of that we'll be thinking about again how do you make this cohesive right because as our family day home educators among

[03:21:32] others will attest and i think where dr mann was going like you can't have like a training on standards here and have it not connected to how we're measuring the quality of classrooms and have it not connected to kind of health and safety expectations like already there's so many things going on and that was even pre-pandemic right and now we've got this pandemic and so really it is forcing us to be to make sure that things are aligned that they're cohesive and that we are delivering this in a kind of a scope and sequence right that is is is understandable and accessible so it's hard to think about that right and kind of how you individualize that but

[03:22:06] that is what we're busy at work doing right now thank you again appreciate it all right i'm looking over the board to see if anybody else has any comments or questions i don't see any so jenna thank you so much and uh happy to meet aaron and i guess that's it uh for that item so let me ask this uh we've been going a few hours again i know we have one major item left anybody willing to take

[03:22:39] a quick break or not take the break all right uh we'll be back at 1 25. all right emily i see

[03:28:39] a bunch of us back you're waiting on francisco i was here sorry i think we're here now right oh i can't tell with miss holton because of the blue screen yeah i can't tell if she's back but

[03:29:01] otherwise yes we're here just say ann are you with us she's on mute miss holton if you're here you're All right, then. I understand that for item M, Dr. Lane is going to do a lead-in. So, Dr. Harris, you've got the best introduction in the world, I guess, coming.

[03:29:39] Well, it's funny that you say that because I am going to do an introduction to our item, but we were notified of something this morning that I thought the board would want to know, and we'll do a more formal recognition at a future board meeting. But we found out today from the Ministry of Education and the Embassy of France that Dr. Harris has been nominated, and I'm not going to say it in French, Lisa, I apologize, my accent in French is terrible, but Dr. Harris has been nominated for the Order of Academic Palms, which is a national order bestowed by the French Republic on distinguished academics and teachers for valuable service to universities, education and science.

[03:30:18] And so Lisa has gotten a huge recognition by the French government for her work in developing language. So I just wanted to say congratulations first to that. That's wonderful. And very good to know. Yeah. So Lisa, congrats.

[03:30:33] But on the item M, I wanted to say that you see a lot of work that comes from the department. But I just wanted to also tell you how impressed I am with the New World Language Standards of Learning.

[03:30:48] it's it's almost a complete rewrite and you know without uh over exaggerating i will say that this is probably our first foray into what competency-based standards can look like and uh just really proud of the work that the team has done here lisa's worked closely with world language teachers throughout the commonwealth to develop this and uh and just excited for the path that this takes us when we think about other standards in the future so uh michael lisa and christine I'll turn it over to you all.

[03:31:24] - Okay, congratulations. And we look forward to hearing from you. - Merci, Dr. Lane. Good afternoon, President Gecker, Vice President Wilson, members of the board and Dr. Lane. I'm honored to be here with you today to present for first review the proposed revised 2021 World Language Standards of Learning.

[03:31:46] I would like to start by acknowledging Dr. Christine Harris, the Director of Humanities for her support and guidance throughout this process. And I'd also like to acknowledge the support of Dr. Lane and Mr. Michael Bolling. We have the next slide, please.

[03:32:05] Most importantly, I'd like to acknowledge the hard work, the concerted efforts and valuable contributions of the teachers and curriculum specialists who served on the steering committee and the writing team. The writing team and steering committee members were selected to ensure balanced representation from across the superintendent's regions for early, mid and late career bands and to ensure we had diverse language backgrounds represented.

[03:32:31] And lastly, I'd like to acknowledge the valuable feedback provided by the external review panel, including representatives from public and private universities, community colleges, and professional language organizations.

[03:32:47] The World Language Standards of Learning have been in place since the early 1980s and have undergone four previous revisions. Of note, in 2017, the name of the standards was officially changed from foreign language to world language with the approval of the revised standards of accreditation.

[03:33:05] On January 23rd of this year, the board approved the timeline to proceed with the new process for reviewing the world language standards of learning. And in accordance with this plan, the department took the following steps to produce the drafts before you today.

[03:33:22] First, public comment was solicited on the current standards. And during this initial comment period, the department received 31 comments on those 2014 standards and a brief summary of those comments is in the boilerplate second we solicited and convened a writing team and steering committee which was made up of teachers and curriculum specialists to review that public comment and consider proposed revisions the world language standards of learning review committee took into consideration national world language readiness standards the advanced placement and international

[03:33:58] baccalaureate requirements as well as the board of education goals and department of education priorities around literacy the profile of a virginia graduate the virginia five c's social emotional learning culturally responsive instruction and equity additionally a group of external stakeholders convened in september to review and provide input on the proposed changes and at the end of this process the comments and suggestions from all the groups were used to complete the proposed revisions before you today so in addition

[03:34:33] to analyzing the public comments the review the review teams used a deliberative process to guide their work on reviewing and recommending changes to the current standards from the onset of the

process we had three goals established for the review the first was alignment of the proposed standards to the profile of virginia graduate specifically the virginia five c's creative and critical thinking communication collaboration and citizenship are really a natural fit with the world language five c's of communication culture connections comparisons and community focus on the

[03:35:11] five c's included additional support for the implementation of language skills and processes as they apply to college opportunities career options and 21st century workplace skills second in our development of the proposed revisions there was an intentional focus on building literacy integrating technology and demonstrating cross-content connections the proposed progress indicators include opportunities for students to explore the impact and the use of current and emerging technologies and to apply that knowledge and skill to other contexts both

[03:35:50] inside and outside the learning environment and third as the teams worked on the proposed revisions Each step included a review through the lens of equity, culturally responsive language and practice, and social emotional learning. The proposed standards seek to maximize the potential of all learners and are respectful of diverse backgrounds and experiences of Virginia's public school students. So based on the feedback from educators in our external panel, five key changes were made

[03:36:24] that will be immediately noticeable. The first and most visible of these changes is a move from aligning to course levels to alignment with proficiency bands. This change is the foundation for the other proposed revisions and was the number one most requested change from public comment.

[03:36:42] Next, you'll see that the proposed revisions move away from separate standards for individual languages and move to universal standards that are grouped by language families. In the strands and structure of the standards, you'll note a new focus on intercultural communication and building literacy the new literacy strand helps break down how to help students access authentic materials at a deeper level not just on the surface and in response to another frequent request the standards were expanded to include examples for elementary

[03:37:18] levels and our previous versions addressed only secondary language courses and finally the proposed revised standards include new standards for visual languages primarily represented in Virginia schools through American Sign Language. ASL, as you know, has been accepted for world language credit by board action since 1997, but to date has not been represented in the standards of learning. In addition, progress indicators will provide guidance for language development for dual language and heritage language programs. So the proposed revised standards have been

[03:37:57] updated to provide a clear structure that has consistency, clarity, and scaffolding of concepts. the structure starts with the three proficiency bands which are in turn organized into strands these strands are based on the three modes of communication interpretive interpersonal and presentational and communicative literacy as i mentioned the communicative literacy is a new strand and those remaining elements from the 2014 strands which were the connections comparisons

[03:38:29] and community strands are now interwoven throughout the communication strands each section of the standards document follows the same format beginning with the strand which represents the mode of communication as i mentioned interpretive interpersonal or presentational and then for each strand the benchmark provides an overarching statement of what learners should know and be able to do communicatively and culturally within each major level of proficiency that's the novice

[03:39:02] intermediate and advanced levels. The goals delineate the desired end result within each sublevel as the learners build their cultural competence and language proficiency with a progression from novice low up through advanced mid. And I'll note that while there are higher levels of proficiency, the selected bands of novice to advanced mid represent the most likely outcomes and reasonable expectations for k-12 programs the strands the benchmarks and the

[03:39:37] goals serve as organizing elements and the standards of course are the bulk of the document and they delineate the knowledge and skills that learners must master within each sub-level to reach the corresponding proficiency benchmark and finally to better help teachers and curriculum developers to interpret the intent of the standards each standard is followed by sample progress indicators that provide examples to show what the standards could look like during learner performance.

[03:40:10] So with that, after the review and revision team completed their work, we presented this information on the proposed revisions to a team of external reviewers and got some initial feedback. And that initial feedback has been overwhelmingly positive.

[03:40:26] Our community college colleagues and representatives from four-year universities were particularly enthusiastic about some of the proposed changes and on the screen here you see a few of the comments from external review team members and i'll mention that in my current role as president of the national council of state supervisors for languages i had the opportunity to survey my colleagues across the country and there are currently around 19 states that have indicated that they are specifically aligning their standards to proficiency bands rather than course levels so this move to

[03:41:01] proficiency alliance standards would put Virginia with these early adopters and then here are some additional comments from members of the external review team on the previous slide you'll see that there was actually two sets of comments the recurring theme that you might notice was support for how the proposed revisions would increase student agency and voice so if the board accepts these standards for first review today the department will post a superintendent's memo announcing a public comment period and a public hearing. And I thank you in advance for your

[03:41:39] willingness to assist with the public hearing. And then the approval review and revision timeline calls for the adoption of the standards in March of 2021. After the board votes on adoption in March, there will certainly be a need for sustained communication to the field, especially to our two and four year colleges colleagues who will need to know how this transition will impact their programs and the students who are moving from the secondary to post-secondary courses. We will certainly include them in all communication and make available

[03:42:16] both print materials and professional development opportunities such as webinars, summer institutes, opportunities for recorded modules and new support documents that will help with the implementation of the standards in the classroom practice so in closing the superintendent of public instruction recommends that the board of education accept for first review the proposed revised world language standards of learning and i'm happy to respond to any questions at this time

[03:42:50] are there any questions at this time no question i just want to say to dr hers felicitations Thank you very much.

[03:43:17] Dr. Duran, do you want to translate for the illiterate among us? I was just telling her congratulations for her award, and I had studied French, so it was nice to be able to use it again. Excellent.

Dr. Harris, thank you very much.

[03:43:34] Mr. Gecker, if I may, yes, thank you, and congratulations, really impressive work, and And I love what Dr. Lane pointed out for us is this is a first venture for us into competency-based approach. That's very exciting. Can you tell me just a little bit more about the heritage learner approach?

[03:43:55] You know, I've had a thought experiment recently with some of my grad students about, you know, what if we, and I don't really mean this as a practical suggestion in any way, but what if we someday took into our accountability standards dual language proficiency and gave schools a bonus for having students who were dual language proficient, which of course would be an amazing skill for workforce preparedness, life preparedness, but just as a thought experiment,

[03:44:31] it makes you realize how monolingual we still are. And so I'm particularly interested in how your heritage learner strands, how does that help our English language learners capitalize on what will ultimately be an amazing skill for them that we don't otherwise accredit in our accountability system, but that they have the basis for as they come into our system, if that makes sense.

[03:45:06] For the non-language folks in our audience, when we talk about a heritage language, we're talking about a minority language, whether it be an immigrant or an indigenous language that's been learned by its speakers at home as children, but never fully developed because of insufficient input from the societal environment. So the speakers grow up with a different dominant language in which they become more competent and have one or more usually insufficiencies in the heritage language that we try to address in programs most commonly those gaps in the knowledge

[03:45:44] base occur in the area of of literacy and they become more functionally fluid in what we often refer to as kitchen table language the language of social interaction that most commonly takes place in a family environment and we need to build on the skills of academic language and literacy and so the heritage language programs take that into account and the sample progress indicators that the team is providing take into account those gaps and skills and also the outcome expectations so rather than expecting every student to come in at the same level of proficiency

[03:46:23] we acknowledge that our heritage learners might come in with already a substantial proficiency in interpersonal communication and so they would start out at a higher proficiency band rather than beginning at the novice band they might start out at novice high or intermediate low but in their presentational writing they might start out at novice mid because they have not had enough opportunity to practice that or as much opportunity as they have those interpersonal oral skills and so the goal of that adding that particular context was to address the needs of those students and honor the fact that they bring some language background with them and provide

[03:47:02] what they need to continue moving forward in that heritage language okay anybody thank you for the attention to the topic and for the additional explanation yeah i don't see anybody else uh again dr harris thank you so much uh you know for the great presentation and you know just clear i mean just very clearly stated what you want to do which is a great thing so thank you and again congratulations thank you and so i guess the board if there is no other discussion will accept this

[03:47:40] on first review and we'll see you again soon okay uh items n and o are written reports uh you have contact information there for n uh dr sale uh for o mr wilcox uh discussion of current issues are there any is there any discussion by members of the board mr geck i just have kind of my monthly updates

uh please will dr lane well first board members i want to thank you so much for the work that you did today sometimes as we're debating these things in 20 and 30 minute segments you

[03:48:19] you may not realize the power of the the decisions that you made today and you made some decisions that will be uh roundly celebrated by the education community i wanted to let you know that uh items g j and k uh that you approved today well g and k specifically required waivers uh through the superintendent's office uh as soon as you voted on those items we submitted those waivers and they've already been approved by the secretary so they're effective as well so i wanted to let you know we'll be putting that information out to the field today um the last thing i just i highlighted

[03:48:55] this a little bit before i talked about item g but i just wanted to let you know um we have seen since September uh when we opened schools a significant movement towards more in-person learning uh throughout throughout the month of October uh and so uh if you get a chance to check out our website we do uh put up a map of the modalities we updated that map as of November 12th and you can actually toggle back to September 22nd and September 8th to see how it's changed uh we'll do another map update here in the new future I will tell you though um uh we're we're

[03:49:32] we're likely going to see a trend of regression over the next couple months with these spiking cases especially with the fears that we have around continued community spread related to holiday events and so you know families that don't normally get together will be getting together more often and unfortunately we think that will lead to COVID spread and if they don't follow great safety mitigation measures in the home and the such and so we've already seen a few of our school divisions that were planning on moving forward with in-person instruction pause their

[03:50:09] plans we think that will continue and maybe some even moving back and so we'll keep you abreast of those changes but if you'd like to know where we are as of about seven days ago if you click on state snapshot on our website you'll be able to see district by district what they're doing other than that mr gecko that's all i have good thank you dr lane uh miss davis pot i uh i would like to if i could dr lane with your permission i'd like to do a very special recognition to all of the the divisions and superintendents and principals that hosted our visit recently

[03:50:45] with your blessing sir we stopped at tazwell county primary school we met with dr stacy and principal ashby and board members there and enjoyed seeing the wrap up at their end of their day with their pre-K children and thank them for their hospitality and then we went the next day early in the morning and visited Lee County and Dr. Austin and Elk Knob Elementary School and saw some wonderful things going on there with their staff and with their children, so thank you Dr. Austin and Elk Knob Elementary School. Also in Scott County at Shoemaker

[03:51:25] Elementary School we had a discussion with Dr. Ferguson, the members of his central office staff and Mrs. Dishner the principal there of Shoemaker Elementary School and we took a tour to see all of that Blue Devil pride down there in that area with their children in the building too so that was a very good visit. We also left Shoemaker and drove up 58 to Norton Elementary and Middle School and met Dr. Wolford who we follow on Twitter. I follow on Twitter and met mr addison the principal there and enjoyed that visit quite a bit from there we took a very fast

[03:52:01] trip up to carroll county middle school and we met dr burnett and um the principal of carroll county middle school mrs burnett and i was very impressed with the things that they had going on there and dr lane had a lengthy discussion there and i can't remember his name sir from um downstairs in the

in the woodshop class and we had a great conversation there and a little bit of a demonstration also with a little welding machine so that was very informative from there we went to we started

[03:52:34] the next day we went to uh well no actually we went to scott memorial middle school and dr lane had a personal connection there with the principal there scott memorial miss kirtner kirtner i'm not not sure if I said her name correctly, and she gave us all a big welcoming with the billboard, the sign, and Dr. Lane and Dr. Myers, and I had a great visit there as well, so thank you for that, Dr. Jeffries and Mrs. Kirtner. We also went to Galax Elementary School and met Ms. Tilly,

[03:53:09] the superintendent there, and I need to do a very special shout out for the PE teacher there, Mrs. Rose Wooten, who not only diversified her, well, she just changed up her lesson to include the Halloween holiday, six feet distancing, masks going above and beyond to do with the physical education class and to keep it safe all around. So very good example for people to see. Smith County, Dr. Carter and Northwood High School, Mr. Ward, very impressed with the visit there

[03:53:44] and the mitigations they're doing for this this very difficult time and I want to say congratulations to all of them and and we got a lesson there with social emotional learning and chronic absenteeism and and just really appreciate that so Dr. Carter was also participating in the SOA committee so great great representation and we went to Grayson County High School and met Superintendent Will more there and and got to see the children who were celebrating nine weeks of good attendance attitude behavior and effort and that was a great visit um delegate oquin joined us there and we met

[03:54:22] a staple in the community who was the school board member um i can't remember her last name but janey and she's affectionately janey to everyone there and and um and i would like to say to all the board members this was a fantastic trip and and i would highly recommend if you have the opportunity to reach out and to visit with Dr. Lane and his staff to see what's going on in the schools. Maybe not so much in the areas that are experiencing the uptick in COVID cases, but it's been an eye-opener for me and I would like to request if Dr. Lane and anyone in your department

[03:54:58] that's taking tours, maybe in Northern Virginia, Beach area, or around Richmond, I would love to see those schools because it's an eye-opener for me as far as instruction, teaching, learning, safety and and the blessings that the the board and and the department are placing upon these schools and the divisions and dr lane a special shout out to you sir for all of the leadership during this critical time and the way you're reaching out to to support all of the division superintendents when your back was turned they rained compliments on you and dr myer myers like it was snowfall so just so that you know that you are being very much appreciated across southwest

[03:55:36] virginia thank you miss davis god i i i apologize forgot to mention that because i meet with the superintendents as you know uh what we were doing every other week now we're doing every uh every week now we're doing every other week and um one of my traditions is i i either wear or show uh the uh the t-shirts of the schools that i visited and so i've i've got one sitting here right here on my desk uh from lee county elk knob middle school and you can see there it says we're in this together six feet apart and so uh we're certainly all in this together and this is my with county stress

[03:56:11] ball you see i've already torn the top of it off uh uh so a lot going on there but but no thank you to everyone in southwest virginia for for the tour and in cases if you don't know the case the case numbers in southwest virginia are are the largest in the state and especially the the areas that border other states that don't have mask mandates uh and and uh i told this story to my staff yesterday and i'll tell it to you that

on state street in bristol uh after we did all our tours one night i walked down state street just to you know get some steps in and on the tennessee side

[03:56:46] of the street you know everything was open people were not physically distancing as much as i as i would expect on the virginia side of the street you saw a lot of safety measures and so it's it's really interesting you can you can almost see the differences in policy as you cross the street and And so, but thank you for coming with us, Ms. Davis-Wad.

[03:57:07] That was a wonderful tour. We did 1,100 miles in three days. And it was, as always, just the best hospitality you can ever imagine when you visit schools in Southwest Virginia. I have visited now well over 100 of our divisions.

[03:57:24] I promised that I would visit all 132 before I got to two years. And then COVID hit, and I couldn't do that in the second half of last year. So we've restarted that. but I have about 25 left. And next up, I'm going to tour region three, which is Northern Neck, Middle Peninsula area.

[03:57:41] And so if any are interested, let me know and I'll let you know when we do that. - Okay, anybody else? I've got just two items. Ms. Holtman? - Yes, thank you. That was just wonderful to hear about that report.

[03:57:59] Thank you, Ms. Davis-Fott and Dr. Lane. And thank you for making that effort. I know the personal touch makes a huge difference for everybody. I also appreciate the updates on where our divisions are. I am in the category of passionately wanting in person as safely possible.

[03:58:19] And really think that it's so important for so many of our students. And yet the case number, as you say, absolutely in the wrong direction, even here in Virginia, even though Virginia is doing much better than many states.

[03:58:36] And so I've been predicting that we will see some movement in what is ultimately the wrong direction but for the right reasons that we will see schools having to school divisions having to go back to virtual or move to virtual in the shorter term in the longer term I am I know I share everybody's hope that we will be back to nearer normal in the not too distant future in light of what we're hearing on the vaccine front now and as painful as that is to think about how we're going to get through the intervening months we will get through them and i just want to encourage everybody on the call

[03:59:14] and and the public sharing in to be as patient and as supportive of your school boards and your superintendents as you can there is no harder job right now they whatever decisions they make they're they're choosing between bad options there are no good options uh and that's going to last until uh the vaccine is more widespread the vaccines are out there and and widespread uptake so um let's all just be kind to each other as much as we can and recognize that while we got a lot of letters today as we often do the public comment was full of letters of uh parents concerned about

[03:59:52] schools not reopening some concerned about reopening but more wanting to push their local divisions to reopen and i totally get that but i i just counsel patience under the circumstances and and trying to be as understanding as you can of people who are making difficult decisions in difficult times for all of us thank you for those and thank you pam for your report let me just mention i guess one thing and then some closing comments and we'll be done uh we have talked before about you know the constitutional requirement to periodically review the adequacy of existing school divisions for promoting the realization of the prescribed

[04:00:30] standards of quality as we saw the consolidation case today uh you know dr lane are we in a position to begin that kind of review and if not that's okay i mean believe me we understand bandwidth issues and priorities and um so this is not i'm putting you on the spot and the answer needs to be yes it is a serious question about are we able to begin that kind of review well Thanks for the question. Being completely honest, bandwidth is going to be tough.

[04:01:07] Revising the SOA is a big project, and I think we're getting into the heaviest period of doing that work. But we're also beginning to learn more and more about the pandemic, and I think there will still be more areas for the board to focus on there. As an example, a hot topic that you will likely see in January and March is what type of flexibility do we want to provide around say teacher evaluation in this setting because you know should should teachers be

[04:01:44] evaluated in the same way when they're not even teaching in the same uh framework that they're used to teaching in and so there are other topics but you know my passion on this on this school boundary topic and and that is I actually believe that uh for us to truly get to equity and truly get to a place where every student is in a high quality school i think the assignment of students is a huge part of that conversation um and so like you i've been receiving the research reports from uh the commonwealth institute and vcu and and and are taking all of those in and what we know is

[04:02:23] that you know there are some in school division boundary issues that that could help with with equity but the the predominant issues are actually between the school district boundaries you know I think I read in one of the reports that 75 of the segregation is is because of the school division lines and 25 of the segregation in the state is within the school divisions and so we'll also run into some authority issues but I being completely honest and that this will be my last comment on this I can't imagine something that would be more important for us to work on but I think we should

[04:03:00] do it methodically i think we should do it slow and make sure we get it right so i would i wouldn't want us to rush to conclusions on anything uh that's fine i just uh i don't want to lose that off the radar screen but i certainly understand not beginning it now uh if we you know don't have capacity uh i've just got you know two more comments uh you know first uh to our staff the doe staff not board staff but the doe staff i mean there is certainly among members of the board and certainly in myself, you know, a pretty good and deep understanding about how hard you work and how dedicated you are to the children of the commonwealth, which is greatly appreciated by,

[04:03:40] you know, me and by the board as a whole. You know, I'll say, you know, today we had that one item where you found the board going against a staff recommendation. And I will tell you that for the board to go against the staff recommendation, at least in me and I'm sure in others, creates a certain feeling of discomfort, right, because you all have expertly served the board for a long time and for us to say, you know, to substitute our judgment for yours honestly does create some discomfort. Occasionally I try to alleviate that discomfort through efforts of humor to the

[04:04:16] extent, you know, I hope that those efforts of humor are not misread. We have, I have the greatest respect and admiration for you know all of you and for the work you do uh this uh for the board is our uh last meeting of the year you know it's a time normally when we'd be thinking about getting together with our families uh going up you know in my case uh you know going to new jersey uh seeing you know the people i don't normally see uh you know it's you know christmas is coming or the

[04:04:52] holiday season is coming. You know, it's easy for us to get lost and focus on what we, you know, don't have anymore, what we can't do this year, frankly, what we shouldn't do this year. You know, the flip side of that is, you know, we can all choose to, you know, count our blessings and I'll tell the members of the board that the opportunity to work with each of you and to the staff and to Dr. Lane, the opportunity to work with each of you is one of the greatest blessings I have. So,

[04:05:23] you know thank you uh for the opportunity uh to serve the children it's been you know truly truly you know outstanding uh experience for me you know i hope that you have a healthy and peaceful season and i guess i will see you in january uh with some luck and uh you know as ann says you know a little bit of patience perhaps we will be able to get together in person sometime soon But until that, thank you for everything.

[04:05:55] Thank you, President Gecker. Thanks, everybody. Happy Thanksgiving. Thank you. Happy Thanksgiving.

